Mark My Words

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/28578420.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra)

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Tattoos, Alternate Universe - Tattoo Parlor, Magical Tattoos, Alternate Universe - Flower Shop & Tattoo Parlor, Soulmate-Identifying Marks, Alternate Universe - Soulmates, Soulmates, Gay

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by lologoblens

Summary

Catra makes it all the way to twenty-five with no tattoos to speak of. Most notably she, unlike so many of her peers, did not rush out to get her soul mark the moment she was of legal age to get tattooed. It was a point of pride, when she was young, to not need to find some supposed soulmate. To not even really want it. Now it's more a matter of practicality. Half the "artists" who claim to harness the magic of soul marks are nothing more than charlatans.

No, she's much better off not bothering. And that's the principal she sticks to, that is until Scorpia's thirtieth birthday rolls around just a month after Honor of Greyskull Ink opens on their block....

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

A Point of Pride

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

✧♏✧

Catra's eighteenth birthday comes, and it passes.

Then her nineteenth, her twentieth, her twenty-first. She makes it all the way to twenty-five with no tattoos to speak of. Most notably she, unlike so many of her peers, did not rush out to get her soul mark the moment she was of legal age to get tattooed. It was a point of pride, when she was young, to not *need* to find some supposed soulmate. To not even really want it. Now it's more a matter of practicality. Half the "artists" who claim to harness the magic of soul marks are nothing more than charlatans.

She doesn't need to waste hundreds of dollars on a permanent mark that she doesn't even get to choose the design of. Not when there's no guarantee that it will even be legitimate. No, more likely she ends up with some bullshit only to never meet anyone with the same mark. And even if she did get it, there's no guarantee her soulmate would also. Of course, most people do get it eventually. Those that can afford to at least. Mostly because of a laissez-faire, why not attitude. So very romantic all of it is.

No, she's much better off not bothering. And that's the principal she sticks to until Scorpia's birthday.

Catra takes her out for a fancy meal. It was bougie and overpriced and pretty far out of her usual budget, but it was her best friend's thirtieth birthday! And if anyone deserved to be treated right, it's Scorpia Dream. Of course, fancy dinner means fancy wine and soon both women are reduced to giggling drunks.

"I'm *thirty!*" Scorpia chuckles loudly as they make their way toward their shared apartment, serpentining along the sidewalk. She stops suddenly, right in front of the flower shop. They live in the building next door, above Mermista's coffee shop-the only reason Catra ever manages to make it to work at Plumeria on time. "I want my tattoo."

Catra blinks in surprise, scrambling in her mind in an effort to sober up but coming up short. "Like from there?"

She points across the street to the tattoo parlor that had opened about a month ago. She hasn't been in yet, saw no reason to bother, but her boss had gone in to welcome the new entrepreneur. Perfuma came back waxing on poetic about the "beautiful soul" who worked there. "Pretty easy on the eyes too." She'd winked in Catra's direction.

Catra had only rolled her own eyes in response, Perfuma is more than a little girl crazy. Once she found out that their types aligned, she started trying to drag Catra into her fawning. Yes, Catra can appreciate a well-built, soft butch but she's never been one to fawn or pine. Her boss still enjoys hassling her about it though. Perfuma's lucky she's impossible to hate, otherwise Catra would *hate* that woman.

Now though, Scorpia is looking in the direction Catra is pointing and nodding eagerly. "We can do it together!"

"*What?*" Catra squeaks back at her enthusiasm. "Do what you want, but I'm not fucking paying for a soul mark."

"Aw." Scorpia pouts. "It won't be as fun to do it on my own."

"No way." Catra shakes her head, ignoring the way the wine makes the world spin.

"Okay, what about just a tattoo then? Something fun, and *I'll* get my mark."

"Scorpia." She warns with a groan. "If you're sure about this, Ill go in with you but Im not paying for a fucking tattoo. I really think you should reconsider though. This place is brand new, untested. You could end up with some stupid tattoo that doesnt mean shit."

"You're such a cynic, Wildcat! Im sure." She leans forward a bit and squints her eyes. "Honor of Greyskull Ink is totally legitimate."

Catra eyes her. "Im not gonna talk you out of this, am I?" Scorpia turns to her, her eyes practically glittering with hope. Catra groans, "Alright let' s go in already."

They walk to the storefront, in all its shiny white and gold glory. A bell tinkles pleasantly when they open the door, sending a shiver down Catra's spine. The lobby is a bright, open room. Crystals and glass baubles litter the space, even hanging down from the ceiling in a couple of the corners. There's a large peace lily by the desk Catra's pretty sure was at Plumeria her last shift. The artist must have come in earlier today, Catra's day off. A few plushy armchairs and a couch circle a small glass coffee table, a stack of portfolios on top of it.

"Hey guys!" Catra looks back to the desk to see who' s greeted them. And then her mind leaves her. She's *gorgeous*, tall and strong looking without being bulky. Her eyes are a stormy grey blue with a clear hint of mischief behind them and she's smiling wide. Her hairdo is stupid though, a normal looking ponytail made silly by a dorky hair poof at the front. It does expose a clean undercut and some very pierced ears though, so that' s hot. "Welcome in."

Catra shakes herself from her stupor in time to hear Scorpia respond. She follows her to the counter, and consequently closer to the woman standing there. "Hello! Hi, Im Scorpia, this is my best friend Catra. We actually live just across the street; can you believe it? Wildcat works over there too. Not in our apartment I mean. Have you met Perfuma?" Her whole face softens and Catra thinks again how stupid this excursion is. Soulmate or not, why doesnt Scorpia just ask out the woman she' s already half in love with? What does she need the universe's approval for anyhow?

The woman is smirking now, and has a single eyebrow raised. She keeps eye contact with Scorpia, allowing Catra to continue staring. "Yeah, she's sweet. Introduced herself the other day. She was actually in here earlier to get a piece done."

Scorpia's eyes glaze over. "Sh-she got a tattoo?"

Her smirk cements itself. "She did."

She shakes herself and clears her throat awkwardly. "That's so cool! She's Catra's boss you know, is why I mentioned her. Why else would I? Um, but she has a tattoo now which is like, so, so great. That's why we're here! We hear you do soul marks."

The artist nods slowly, her grin never slipping, and finally turns to look at Catra. She eyes her up and down, making Catra's skin crawl pleasantly. Then her attention is back on Scorpia. "We do-well, I do. Our other artists dont work with soul magic."

"So cool! Do you take walk-ins?"

Adora narrows her eyes, still smirking at them. "You're drunk."

"*What?*" Scorpia replies in a way that definitely makes her sound drunk. "No! A little tipsy maybe. We had wine. It's my birthday."

"Happy birthday." She says, not bothering to argue back about their sobriety.

"So"…

The woman huffs, smirk slipping but a good-natured smile taking its place. She hops on a stool Catra hadnt noticed before and crosses her arms on the desk in front of her. "Do you two know how the process works?"

She looks between them and Catra looks to Scorpia, letting her take the question. This isnt her field trip. "Sort of! You choose a design, and the magic helps you pick whatever will match our soulmates,

right?" Catra rolls her eyes at the use of the word 'our', she is so not getting roped into this.

"Hm." The mischief in the woman's eyes bumps up a notch and Catra's gut twirls. She needs water and to go to bed. "That's the bones of it, sure. I don't just *choose* though, and the magic doesn't just help me decide. What's really happening is the magic helps me to make soul connections more easily. In order for me to learn your mark, I have to know your soul. I can't do that if your judgment is clouded, it's a matter of consent. No good artist should tattoo you when you're drunk, but if someone agrees to give you a mark like this the connection won't be genuine and the mark won't be legitimate."

"Oh." Scorpia frowns, deflating slightly.

"Call me tomorrow, if you're still interested." she says kindly. "We can make an appointment. Marks take time, I don't do them as walk ins anyhow."

"Okay!" Scorpia perks up instantly. "I will do that! Let's go, Wildcat."

She turns and walks away but Catra is stuck. Her head has tipped unconsciously to the side and she's staring at the artist. She looks back at her in amusement. "Yes?"

"You're the real deal, huh?"

"Hmm, a cynic I take it?"

Catra shrugs. "Too poor to waste money on a scam."

She laughs and nods. "Well, it's smart to be cautious but yeah, I'm not out to scam anyone. Just a romantic."

"What about you?"

"What about me?"

"You find your soulmate yet?"

With a smirk and a wink, she answers, "Not yet."

Catra blinks owlishly and nods. "Interesting." And without another word she walks toward the door where her best friend waits, watching intently.

"Hey Wildcat."

Catra turns with her arms crossed. "Don't call me that."

Adora just smirks back at her. "You gonna call me tomorrow too?"

Catra scoffs. "Don't bet on it. What's your name anyway?"

"Adora, my name is Adora."

"Adora." Catra tries it out, it feels good. "Well, I'll see you around, I guess."

"See you around." She waves and Catra turns away again, making her way back toward her friend, their apartment, and her bed.

Scorpia was *not* fucking around and calls Adora the very next morning. She makes an appointment for the following day at two thirty and begs Catra to go with. She puts on a show, fussing about it, but eventually agrees to go. Scorp's appointment is half an hour after her shift on Sunday and it's not like she has anything better to do. By the time Catra finishes her shift that day and makes it upstairs to eat something, Scorpia is bouncing on her heels.

"I'm so excited!"

Catra rolls her eyes. "I know you are, Scorp. And do you know how I know?"

"Because I keep saying it every five seconds?" She suggests, making an attempt to sound bashful about it.

"Because you keep *saying it* every five fucking seconds." Catra confirms.

"It's just so exciting! I never got it before because I didn't want to get disappointed if I never found the person. It's just... something feels *right* about it now."

"Well then I'm excited for you."

"Aww! Thanks Wildcat. Are you um... are you done eating now?"

Catra gives her a look then turns her eye pointedly to the clock. "Your appointment isn't for fifteen minutes."

"You know what they say, if you're early you're on time and if you're on time you're late."

She takes a second to wrap her mind around that then says, "No fucking wonder you have anxiety. Go get your shoes on."

"Yay!" Scorpia scampers off with Catra trailing at a much more leisurely pace behind her. They throw on their Birks and make their way out of the apartment then across the street.

The bell tinkles again when they walk in, and the hairs on Catra's arm raise. Instead of Adora standing at the counter they find a gangly looking black guy in a crop top that says, "2Gay 2Function."

"Nice shirt." Catra snorts as they approach the counter.

He smiles wide and looks down like he can't remember what he's wearing or something. "Thanks! Welcome in, did you have an appointment today?"

"Sure do!" Scorpia answers. "Well, I do. Catra here is my moral support."

"Nice one." He turns to grin at Catra then looks back to Scorpia to ask, "You must be with Adora, right? Or you're *really* early, Glimmer doesn't have anyone on the books until four"...

"Yes! We met her the other night. She is just so nice, isn't she?"

"She sure is!" He clicks around on a computer, nods, then hands her a clipboard. "You're getting your soul mark?"

"I am!"

"That's so exciting." He says encouragingly. "Adora's the best there is, in my rather biased opinion. Just go ahead and fill that form out and I'll go grab her for you."

They take a seat on the overly soft couch, it's like sitting on a giant cotton ball, and Scorpia fills out her paperwork. While she does, Catra picks up one of the portfolios. Bow's it looks like. His work is cool, lots of hyper realism, a few portraits that are pretty dope. She tosses it down and picks up the next. Glimmer's, this one says, it's much less Catra's vibe. Lots of cutesy imagery and bright colors. She tosses it back on the table without looking through to the end.

The last is, obviously, Adora's. Her art is...interesting. Good interesting, just not exactly what Catra would have guessed. It's all very delicate and fine, with some psychedelic coloring and imagery interspersed. Lots of space and star themed stuff too. It's all...really beautiful. Bow and Adora emerge into the lobby out of nowhere and Catra practically hurls the book away from her.

If Adora's smirk is anything to go by, she doesn't miss the action.

"Scorpia, Catra, welcome back!"

"Adora, hi! Gosh, I'm so excited. And nervous. Mostly excited though! Thank you so much for fitting me in."

Adora just waved her off. "Of course, I'm glad you're excited and it's totally normal to be nervous. Bow said Catra's here for moral support?" She looks to Catra and she nods back. "Great! You can come back once we start inking, but Scorpia," she turns to her, "I like to keep it one on one while we're getting to know each other and figuring out your design. Is that okay?"

"Sure! You don't mind, do you, Wildcat?"

She sees Adora bite her lips at the nickname from her periphery and narrows her eyes. "Whatever, I'll wait."

"Thanks Wildcat! Do you mind watching my purse for me?"

"Sure thing, Scorp." She takes the black back and swings it over her shoulder.

"All set?"

"Yep!" Scorp tells her marker.

"Great!" Adora responds, beckoning Scorpia to follow her. "Just come on back with me and we'll get started."

They disappear down the hall to the left of the counter and Catra is left alone with Bow. He's returned to his seat behind the counter but is still looking over at Catra.

"Yes?"

"Adora said you work across the street, with Perfuma?"

"Oh, yeah, I guess."

Bow laughs. "Is that a question?"

She rolls her eyes at him and stands to drift closer. She's not really sure why she's allowing herself to be dragged into conversation, but

here she is, leaning against the counter and doing just that. "No, I work there."

"Are you as into plants as Perfuma?"

"*No one* is as into plants as Perfuma."

Another easygoing laugh. "Okay , fair."

"I just like making the bouquets."

Bow's eyebrows raise. "Oh yeah?"

"Whatever , flowers are cool." She leaves it at that and deflects. "You're an artist?"

"Sure am! I've been working with Adora forgosh, long time now . Didn't think twice about coming with her when she said she wanted to open a shop all together."

Catra nods slowly. "Right. So, she gave you a soul mark too?"

"Huh?"

"You just said before, about her being the best and you being biased"…

"Oh, right. Yeah, Adora gave me my mark. Glimmer too."

"And have you found your soulmate or whatever?"

He smirks. "Sure have." Catra stares at him, unwilling to take the bait he's offering. After their staring goes on a minute or two, he blinks, breaking the contact and laughing. "It's Glimmer, our other artist."

"Oh, weird. Is that like a coincidence or"…

He shakes his head. "Not exactly . She got her mark a couple months back, but we've known each other a long time. Longer than Adora

and I even. We actually dated in high school."

"Huh."

"Y eah."He shrugs. "T iming is a funny thing."

"I guess so, yeah."

"D you have yours?"

"My what?"

"Y our mark."

"Psh, no."Realizing how her dismissal may have come of f she continues on to explain, "I mean, to each their own but, no. I never really wanted to."

"W ell, if you ever do, I cant recommend Adora enough. There' s a lot of skeezy people out there but she' s one of the good ones."

She hums in thought, her eyes drifting down the hall without her permission. After a prolonged minute she stands abruptly upright. "I think Im gonna go across the street for a cof fee, you want anything?"

"Oh!"He looks a little startled. "Uh, a green tea if you dont mind. I can venmo you if that's okay"…

She just waves him of f, already walking toward the door. "Dnt sweat it."Then she books it across the street to Sealineas Cof fee Co.

Mermista is bickering with Hawk behind the counter when she walks in, and the familiar sight soothes her.

"Catra!"Mermista barks out as she approaches the counter . "Please tell this man that *no one* is going to order a flambe coffee."

Catra scrunches her face in disgust. "What the fuck, Hawk? You fucking pyro."

"It's *fun*!" He insists.

"You know what *isn't* fun?" Mermista bites back. "When my insurance goes through the damn roof because you started *another* fire. Watch your step or the next thing to be fired will be *you*!"

"*Ooh*, burn!" Mermista levels her with her a look and it takes her a second to deduce why. When she does, she snorts. "Okay , you know I dont intentionally do puns."

"Whatever . What do you want?"

"Such service in this place." She teases. It doesnt get a response. "Alright just a cortado and a twelve ounce green tea please."

"Green tea?"

"Uh yeah?"

Mermista glares back. "Be *more* vague, I dare you."

"Wow, touchy today, okay." She holds her hands up in submission. "It's not for me, I literally do not care what you put in that cup."

"Fine."

"You okay, Merms?" Catra ventures, a little softer .

She groans and sets to work on Catra's order. Evidently realizing he's been dismissed, Sea Hawk makes himself scarce, setting to work on restocking pastries. "I'm *fine*, my parents are just in town. My *father* has some opinions on how I ought to run *my* business."

Catra sucks her teeth. "Ouch."

She gives Catra a droll look. "If I didn't know it would be insensitive as fuck, I'd tell you how lucky you are not to have parents."

She just snorts. "If I gave a shit about having parents, I'd tell you to fuck off."

Mermista laughs and a little bit of weight lifts from her shoulders. "What are you doing anyway? Who the fuck do you know that drinks green tea? Perfuma's all about that herbal shit."

"Have you met the new artists?" She gestures to the tattoo shop across the way. "Bow?"

"Oh sure," she waves and absent hand. "you know how it is, everyone needs coffee."

"Right, duh."

"You getting a piece?"

She shakes her head. "Nah, Scorp's getting her mark though."

Mermista's eyebrows raise and she pushes two to go cups over the counter. "That's big."

A shrug. "I guess, yeah."

"You ever think about getting yours?"

"Eh, I've never been all that motivated. I don't want to get scammed either. This new girl seems legit though."

"Adora?" Catra nods. "Yeah, Fuma said the same thing after she got her mark."

"That's right, they mentioned she'd been in for a tattoo." She snorts. "Scorpia about lost her shit. How funny would it be if they ended up being soulmates?"

She snorts. "I can see it actually ."

Catra shrugs, she can too honestly. "What about you? Ever think about getting one?"

Mermista rolls her eyes. "Why bother? I already know it' s Hawk, no other reason I'd put up with his shit."

"Oof, you sure you don't wanna know for certain?"

She laughs. "Fuck of f, that's my man you're dissing."

"Oh, like you don't know he deserves it."

"T rue," she admits, then mutters, " *fucking flambe coffee*. He must have been dropped on his head, right? Like, only brain damage could explain that."

"Y eah, I dunno, dude. I think that may just be like, who he is as a person." Mermista groans and Catra laughs at her . "Y ou're a lucky woman, Mermmy."

"Shut up, get out of my shop."

"I'm going, I'm going." Catra grabs her cups to do just that, dropping some cash on the counter before she goes. "Good luck with the parents."

Mermista just flips her of f and a laughing Catra walks out of the shop and across the street. She feels much more chill than when she left. Bow is gone when she returns so she drops his cup at the desk and falls into a poufy couch to scroll through her phone.

After another half hour or so she hears voices coming from the hall and looks up. The first thing Catra notices when Scorpia exits the back room is that she's been crying. Her face is pink, eyes still watery, and there are dried tear tracks on her cheeks.

She and Adora are talking quietly and Catra stands abruptly, making her way over to them. "The fuck did you do?" She demands fiercely.

Adora smirks and raises her eyebrows. "Pardon me?"

"She's been crying." Catra gestures to her very best friend in the world, who she will protect with her life if it comes to it. "What happened back there?" She turns her back on Adora and faces Scorpia fully. "Scorp, are you okay?"

"Woah, woah, slow down there, Wildcat! Adora was very sweet to me. You know me, I'm a hugger *and* a crier."

Catra feels herself deflate at the remind and pulls back, allowing Adora to be part of the conversation once more. "Oh so, you're not upset?"

"Not at all! Adora here is the sweetest."

"Oh." She grimaces and turns to Adora, rubbing at the back of her neck. "Sorry for like, jumping on you or whatever."

Adora just chuckles and waves her off. "Nah, it was cute." She turns to Scorpia and smirks. "She really lives up to that nickname, huh?"

"Oh yah!" Scorpia laughs along with her. "Catra is *very* fierce." She wraps an arm around Catra's shoulders, unaware of the extent of her strength she practically pulls her into a chokehold. "Especially when she's being protective, very loyal our Wildcat."

Catra shoves and pushes at her arm until she manages to pull free with a growl. "I hate both of you." She points a finger in each of their directions for good measure. It doesn't seem to be as effective as she would hope, unfortunately.

"Alright, well, now that's settled shall we get going on this mark?"

There's a general consensus and Adora leads them back to another room. There's a tattoo table with a chair for the artist along one wall.

In another corner is an armchair, nearly as poufy as those in the lobby. Catra can't suppress her eyeroll.

"What is with the damn seating in this place?"

Adora looks to her with a raised eyebrow and Scorpia looks a little bashful on her behalf. "Glimmer ."

Catra laughs shortly. "The other artist?"

Adora nods and indicates that Scorpia sit. "Y up, I don't have much of an eye for interior design, so I just gave her the reigns."She grimaces and pulls on a pair of gloves with a sharp snap. "But yeah, the seating is *way* too soft. I'm just glad I didn't let her touch my room."

"Is this not your room?"

Adora shakes her head. "W e share the tattooing spaces. I'm talking about the meeting room where Scorpia and I just were."

"Ohh!"Scorpia pipes up. "Those chairs *were* very nice."

"Y eah, well I have to sit in those."Adora laughs.

Catra scoffs in amusement. "Ah, I see. So, the poufy unsupportive crap is good enough for the rest of us, but not Adora."

"Exactly ."She winks. It occurs to Catra that the room is rather warm. She takes off the flannel she's thrown over her tank top and shorts. "Alright, Scorpia do you have any other tattoos?"

"Just one!"She taps her thigh;the ink is covered by her shorts but Catra knows she has a small crab under there.

"Great!So, you have some idea what to expect. Mostly this will feel the same, but the ink I use is a bit different-"

"D ferent how?"Catra interrupts without thought.

Adora looks to her to answer, her smile is mischievous as all hell. "Magic."

She snorts. "Of course."

Turning back to Scorpia, Adora continues. "So, itll feel sort of… warm. If and when you see a matching mark it may feel warm again. Not everyone reports as much, but those who do say it generally lasts about three to ten minutes."

"Got it!"

With that Adora gets to work. She cleans and shaves Scorpia's bicep and applies a stencil. Catra squints at it. "Is thatis.that a scorpion ouroboros?"

"Sure is."Adora answers without looking up from her task.

"Damn, that' s a dope mark. Arent most abstract?"

"Hmm,"Adora hums, distracted. Catra wonders if she should shut up, why does she suddenly care about this crap?"A lot yeah, but it' s not super rare for them not to be by any means."

A machine flips on, filling the room with its buzCatra wants to ask if the machine has to be different if the ink is, but she keeps her mouth shut. Scorpia takes the pain like a champ, fixing her eyes on the art on the walls. They're pretty cool actually , past tattoo designs of all three resident artists if she's not mistaken.

About forty minutes go by and, as Adora wipes away excess ink, she checks in. "How ya holding up Scorpia?"

"Oh, great!"

"Okay , just let me know if you need a break."

"Hey Scorp, you should probably drink some water ."Both women turn to look at her and she draws back. "What?Y ou get dehydrated.

A lot actually."

Scorpia laughs boisterously. "When you're right, you're right. Do you mind, Adora?"

"Not at all!" She rolls back on her stool so Scorpia can stand and take the bottle Catra is holding out for her. "So, how long have you two know each other?" Scorp laughs again and Catra looks up in the direction of the stars. "Oh, there's a story, isn't there?" The eagerness in Adora's voice is audible.

"Eh, not a long one." Scorpia answers honestly. "I was Catra's babysitter." Catra groans and the sound is met with more laughter. "Yep, my first job was taking care of Wildcat, and now she takes care of me! The world is a funny place."

Catra knows when she looks down, she's gonna be met with Scorpia's damp heart eyes. She does though, because she knows how much Scorpia loves to love her. Even if it makes her squirm a little. Sure enough, that's exactly the sight that greets her. What she doesn't expect is a similar expression on Adora's face, just minus the misty eyes.

"Oh my fucking stars, it's so not that big of a deal."

"It's cute." Adora tells her.

"Psh, you don't know what a terror I was back then. I had a biting phase." She bares her teeth and Adora raises a smug eyebrow at her.

"Weirdly, that tracks."

"You know, I'm really not sure how to take that so I'm just gonna roll right past it. Are you dummies gonna start again or what?"

"Love you, Wildcat."

"Yeah, yeah. Love you too Scorpy." She grumbles back. The cooing in response embarrasses her and she ices them out by pulling out her phone and scrolling.

Another half hour or so passes and Scorpia speaks up this time. "Can I ask you a kind of personal question?"

"You can ask, I might not answer."

"Totally fair! I was just wondering, is the process of becoming a soul marker the same as other tattoo artists? Like apprenticing and stuff?" Catra tucks her phone back in her pocket.

"Oh, yeah actually! A lot of markers actually find out they have the connection that way. It's kind of luck finding someone to take you on as an apprentice who also happens to have the same magic. Of course, a lot of people who buy into soulmates think meeting your mentor is destiny or whatever. The marks of apprentices and mentors tend to share some sort of imagery, if they dont just match. So that kind of supports the theory."

"That's so cool!" Adora smiles but still doesnt look up from Scorpia's arm. "Is that how it went for you?"

"Nuh-uh, it runs in families a lot of times. My big sister mentored me." Scorpia coos and Adora actually flicks her eyes up for a moment to smile at her.

"So, do your marks share imagery? Wait, do you even have your mark?"

"I do. And yeah, there's a detail on each of ours that match exactly. Thematically they're pretty different though."

"Can I ask what the detail is?"

"Mm, it's a constellation, Cygnus."

"That's the swan, right?" Catra asks.

"It is, yeah."

"So, if you two both found your soulmates all four of you would share that detail? That's pretty special." Scorpia muses.

"Oh." Adora laughs. "I actually never really thought about it. Honestly, we'll probably never know. Mara's married, and I doubt her wife will ever get her mark."

"Why's that?" Scorpia frowns down at her.

"Hmm, a few reasons. I think she's just really practical mostly. She's committed to Mara, so she doesn't care what her soul mark says. And she's not really the tattoo type anyhow."

"Aw, well that's pretty romantic."

"I think so too. Mara gives her shit for it, but she doesn't really care either. I think she's more curious than Hope though. Partly cause of the thing about markers not having mates."

"Wait, what?" Catra cuts in, sitting up in her seat. Or trying to anyway.

"Oh, yeah." Adora wipes Scorpia's arm again and it's looking *really* good. "It's a myth as much as anything, but a lot of people think something about the magic rules out any one soulmate for you."

"That doesn't seem fair." Scorpia says, back to frowning.

Adora does a little half shrug. "Maybe, but the marks are also about more than a mate."

"What do you mean?" Catra asks.

"It's a really personal thing, you know? A lot of people do end up with their match but also, not that many people actually want to wait around. Most people don't wait past thirty-five before finding a partner who isn't a match or doesn't have their mark. I think it's

something like eighty-three percent of people who haven't found their soulmate by then end up with someone without a shared mark."

"Wait, there are statistics about this shit?"

She snorts. "Of course there are. Anyway, you can also have more than one, or it can be a platonic connection, sometimes it's even familial. So, getting your mark-well Scorpia, you and I talked about this, but it should be for *you* ultimately. You're the one who's gonna have to live with it after all. And it's a really intimate thing to not only know about yourself but also to display openly."

"I guess I never really thought about it like that."

"Makes sense, the romantic element of it is really sensationalized. Everyone loves a love story, right?"

"Yeah." Catra eyes her , she's so focused on her work she doesn't seem to notice. She looks kinda dorky with her eyes squinted and the tip of her tongue poking out to one side. It's pretty cute honestly. Catra shakes the thought off.

When silence falls again, she pulls her phone back out. Nearly an hour passes before Adora finally announces that they're done. She directs Scorpia to a long mirror on the back of the door. Scorp gushes over the mark and Adora preens while simultaneously waving off her compliments.

"Catra?" Scorpia turns to her . "Isn't this the *coolest* thing you've ever seen."

Catra looks to Adora when she answers. "Yeah, it's dope, Scorp."

Adora grins back widely. "I'm glad you're so happy with it, Scorpia. Ready to go to the front?"

"Just about!" Adora smiles at her again and leads them back to the desk after wrapping the tattoo and going over aftercare. Bow has

resumed his post and grins widely at them when the emerge.

"How did it go?"

"*So* great!" Scorpia enthuses. "Check it out."

She shows off her mark and Bow shares a conspiratorial look with Adora. Who knows what the fuck that's about? Catra decides not to worry about it when all he says is, "Damn, that's one of the more badass marks I've seen."

"Isn't it!" She squeals. "Adora, it was cash only, right?"

Adora chuckles and circles the counter. "It is, yeah."

Scorpia nods and takes her purse back from Catra. "How much was all this anyway?" She asks nosily.

"Fifty." Adora answers simply.

"*Fifty?*"

Adora meets her eyes and her voice is even when she tells her, "Soul marks shouldn't be inaccessible."

Catra's too stunned to respond. She's pretty sure most markers charge hundreds for this kind of thing. Like, at least twice the price of a regular tattoo. Bow smiles at Adora like she's his fucking hero or something. Then he turns to Catra. "People usually choose to tip generously if they can." He turns to Scorpia and very earnestly tells her, "No pressure of course!"

She just waves him off, finally digging out her cash and handing Adora what is *definitely* more than fifty bucks. "Already planned ahead! Thank you so much, Adora. Really."

"My pleasure. Come back anytime."

"Will do! Alright, Wildcat, you ready?"

Catra stares at Adora. Where the fuck did this woman come from? Adora looks uncertain under her gaze. "Uhh, yes?"

"Fifty?" She asks again.

Adora snorts, relaxing. "Yes?"

Vaguely Catra sees Bow and Scorpia exchanging a look from her periphery. "How long have you been doing this anyway?" She leans against the counter, arms crossed in front of her.

"Charging fifty?"

Catra shakes her head. "All of it."

"Oh, like ten years." She looks to Bow.

"Just shy of." He confirms and she nods before turning back to Catra.

"Why do you ask?" Adora inquires.

Catra stares back at her, not really sure what she's thinking, her brain too muddled up. "You're like, really for real, huh?"

Adora throws her head back and laughs. She tips forward again and wipes a tear of mirth from the corner of her eye. "Yeah, Catra, I'm like really for real. Why? You rethinking getting your mark or something?"

"Why did you get yours?" Catra asks instead of answering.

She raises and eyebrow. "Honestly?"

"No." Catra tells her sarcastically with a roll of her eyes. "Lie to me."

"Fair enough. Practice." When Catra is clearly unsatisfied with that answer she continues, "My own mark was the first I ever did. It's that way for most people unless they've already been marked. You

should know what it feels like before you do it to someone else. Besides, better to fuck up on your own body than someone else's."

Catra hums, that makes sense. "Would you have gotten it if you weren't a marker?"

Adora makes a face of amusement and leans on the counter across from Catra, mirroring her posture. It puts Adora's nose just six inches from hers. She pretends not to notice, despite the way her heart thrums at the closeness. "Well, that's hard to say."

"How so?"

"I don't even know who I'd be if I weren't a marker…"

"It's really that much a part of your identity?"

"Yep."

"Why?"

Adora laughs. "That's a really hard question to answer, Catra." She raises an eyebrow. "Personal too."

Catra huffs out a laugh. "Okay, yeah. Sorry if it was too-"

"You're fine." Catra sucks her teeth and nods. "So?"

"So what?"

"I'm about to start sweating over here, Cat. I feel like I'm in an interview. Did I get the job?"

Catra laughs. "Well, you're certainly qualified." she teases.

"I have an appointment next Wednesday, it's yours if you want it."

Catra eyes her and seriously considers the offer. Does she want to get a mark in less than a week? Does she even want it at all? Why

the hell not?"

Adora perks up and stand upright. "Yeah?"

"Wait, Wildcat, really?" Scorpia is suddenly standing at her shoulder.

Catra nudges her away with her shoulder. "Don't make a big thing of it."

Adora adopts a more serious look and tells her, "Oh, it's a big thing, Catra. Are you sure about this?"

"*Please* don't encourage her, but yes, I'm sure."

"Great!" Catra ignores her best friend who is practically buzzing beside her to give Adora her full attention. "How does three on Wednesday sound?"

"I'll be here."

Adora smirks at her and Catra's stomach flips. "See you then, Catra."

"See you then, Adora."

And then, without ceremony, she drags Scorpia out of the parlor and back to the apartment.

Catra is restless in the days leading up to her appointment, she can't explain it. Maybe it's just the burning curiosity of it all. Whatever it is, by Wednesday morning she's tapping her toes with all her built up energy. It doesn't help when a customer comes in to pick up their order of a dozen blooming begonias. That feels like a bad sign.

When she starts fretting to Perfuma she waves her off. "I think you're making the right decision, Catra." she assures her. "It is very liberating to know yourself in such an intimate way."

Catra frowns at her. "Maybe you're right. It's just so permanent. Besides, I can totally live with never finding my soulmate but what if I *do* find them and they totally suck?"

Her boss hides a giggle behind her hand. "I'm sure any soulmate of yours will be entirely lovely."

Catra huffs and looks at the clock. It's a quarter till two. She has fifteen minutes left of her shift and then an hour after that before her appointment. "What if I don't like the design?"

"Then you don't have to have it tattooed. She'll show you first silly."

"Wouldn't it be like, rude though?"

"It's *your* soul, it's not like you're insulting Adora's creativity."

"Whatever." Catra shuts up then, refilling the bucket of forsythia by the door to fill up the last few minutes of her shift.

She's about to clock off when Perfuma pipes up again. "Maybe you should bring some flowers."

"Flowers?" She turns to give her a doubtful look.

"A nice gesture." Perfuma shrugs. "We just got that beautiful delivery of daffodils."

"Daffodils, really?" Catra levels her with a look. Perfuma smirks and huffs.

"Catra, I'm sure she won't know enough to read into it."

"Yeah, I'm still not bringing a near stranger *daffodils*."

"Well, what do *you* think would be an acceptable message?" Catra looks around the shop and spots the perfect thing. She points and Perfuma smiles warmly. "Oh yes, that should be just perfect."

Catra nods, wraps up Adora's flowers and heads upstairs for a little lunch before her appointment. An hour later she's popping right back out and across the street. Her nerves still tickle her belly, but she's fucking ready for this.

"Hey Wildcat." Adora smirks at her from the counter the moment the door swings open. Stupid Adora and her stupid sexy smirking. Still, the unwelcome nickname is enough to settle Catra's stomach.

Catra stalks over with a growl, shoving the bouquet of daisies into her hands. "Don't call me that! What is wrong with you?"

"Oh, all kinds of things." Adora winks and Catra's stomach appears to be under the impression that it's on a roller coaster or something. "Thanks for the flowers. Are you ready to go back?"

"Sure, whatever." With a nod Adora sets her flowers on the counter and leads her back into a small room. There are two chairs facing each other, neither so poufy as the ones in the waiting room which is nice. Some actual lumbar support even. There's also a small table with candles and stones and a small oil diffuser. The room smells of jasmine and sage.

"Sit wherever." Adora tells her, closing the door behind her. Catra drops into the closest chair and waits. Adora fusses with something on the small table. When she walks over, she holds out two pink stones. One looks clearish, kind of like a pink quartz and the other is a more solid pink, with a bit of green interspersed.

Catra looks up at her. "What am I supposed to do with these?"

"Look, Catra, this is soul magic, okay? It's about to get pretty woo in here."

"Pretty woo?" She parrots back, pursing her lips to keep from laughing outright.

Adora huffs, a smile on her face. "Yes, I know you're a cynic and all, but you're gonna have to give a little. Now, take these," She presses one stone into each of Catra's hands. "close your eyes and give me back whichever doesn't feel right."

"What if neither feels right?" She challenges, not even understanding what "right" would feel like.

Adora just shrugs. "Then we try some others, but I have a good feeling. And if they both do you can hang onto them both."

Catra looks at the stones in her hands and back to the girl in front of her. "You're serious." Adora says nothing. "Do I really have to close my eyes."

Adora rolls hers. "Do you just enjoy being difficult or?"..

"Alright, alright, Ill close my damn eyes." She does as she's asked and focuses on the feeling of each stone in her palm. The quartz like one in her right hand feels fine. Like a rock she supposes. It's cool and rough, unpolished. The stone in her left hand is smooth, shaped into a small tower. It feels warm in her hand, comforting. A sense of calm washes over her when she focuses on it.

She blinks her eyes open and hands the first stone back. Adora smiles, no hint of teasing in the expression for once. "I thought the rhodonite might work for you."

She sets the stone back on the table beside her and then takes a seat. Catra unconsciously runs her thumb up and down over the stone in her hands. "So what now?"

Adora leans back in her chair, crossing her right ankle over her left knee, and regards her. Catra shuffles under the look and pulls her feet up to sit cross legged in her chair. "Hm, well, sometimes I do tarot or just talk, get to know the other person, I even did tea leaves once."

"You're kidding." Catra snorts.

"I'm really not." Adora smiles. "I think we should just sit."

"Sit?" She verifies, the woman across from her just nods. "We're gonna make a soul connection by just sharing the same air."

"Mhm." Catra opens her mouth to argue but closes it when she realizes she actually has nothing to say.

They fall into silence, a small water feature in the corner Catra hadn't noticed previously providing ambient noise. It's surprisingly comfortable. A minute or so in, Adora's eyes drift closed and her head tips back. Catra takes the opportunity to just look at her.

With her head tipped like that her neck looks long and elegant, which might be weird to think but there it is. As Catra watches, without opening her eyes or shifting her position at all, Adora reaches up and frees her hair from its usual confines. Her hair falls, cascading down the back of the chair and it's much longer than Catra ever realized. It looks soft and so, so shiny. Her cheeks and lips look soft too, and dark pink.

Catra feels herself turn red at the observation and Adora's lips turn down into a frown. Catra turns away for fear of being caught staring and looks around the room. There's really not much more to it. A lamp in the corner providing soft light, a large aloe in a simple plant stand. They sit like that for a little bit, Catra just sort of staring around the room, and Adora sitting with her eyes shut.

There's a Georgia O'Keefe print of two bleeding hearts stacked on the wall across from her. She studies that for a while, it really is beautiful. Just as the warmth and the lavender scent in the air start getting to her, and she's starting to get drowsy, Adora's voice softly calls, "Catra?"

She turns to look. Adora is sitting forward again, she's running a hand through her hair and she looks troubled. "What's up?"

"I'm really sorry, I... I can't."

Catra's stomach bottoms out. "Can't what? Connect with my soul or whatever?"

Adora shakes her head. "I can't make your mark."

"What? Why the fuck not?" Catra narrows her eyes and Adora bites her lip, looking down to inspect the soul of her sneaker.

"It's... hard to explain."

"Hard to explain?" She nods without looking up. "Is there... I don't get it, is something wrong? *With me?* She can't help but add in her head.

Adora's head shoots up, her eyes wide. "No! No, it's just complicated and..."

"Hard to explain." Adora nods solemnly. "I see. But you... saw it or whatever? My design." She nods again. "Okay, maybe you can't make the mark, but can you at least draw it out or some shit?" She shakes her head. "Damnit Adora!"

"I'm *sorry*." She says it like she means it. "I just... I need a second to- to wrap my mind around it."

"What the fuck does *that* mean?"

"I-it-I'm-it's comp-"

"Complicated." Catra interrupts. "Yeah, I heard you." She frowns and considers Adora for a moment. Definitely troubled. "Is this... has this ever happened before?"

"Not exactly..."

"Okay... you said you just need a second, is this like you can never do it? Or just not right now?"

She bites her lip. "I'm not sure."

"So what now?"

"Um." She looks so young suddenly, without all her usual cocksure bravado.

"Do you want me to go?"

"I- no, but I guess we're done for today."

Catra nods, unsure how to take that. "Okay, well I need a fucking drink or something." She grabs her bag and stands, holding the stone in her hand out to Adora.

She doesn't take it. "No, that's yours now."

Catra looks down at it doubtfully then back to the enigma before her. "What the fuck am I supposed to do with a rock?"

A hint of Adora's smirk surfaces. "I dunno, decoration, paper weight, whatever you want."

A short laugh and a roll of her eyes and then, "Gee thanks."

And without another word she gives Adora an awkward two finger salute and makes her way out of the parlor. She sees Glimmer and Bow giving her weird looks on her way out. She opts to breeze right past them, uninterested in exchanging niceties.

She takes a sharp right toward the tavern. She debates going alone but decides that's too pathetic. It might be five o'clock somewhere, but it's still early in Brightmoon. Instead Catra pulls out her phone to text Scorpia. She walks the final three blocks with her head down and heart hammering, unsure what the fuck just happened back there.

Chapter End Notes

A one shot? Who? Me? I would *never*....
It was gonna be, once upon a time. Now it'll be three, more likely 4 chapters. So I did that (again).

Anyway, I love the language of flowers and symbolism in general and *went off* with this story. There's 17 in this chapter and 39 (and counting) in the entirety of the story . I have a running list I can share if it's of interest. 👧
Edit: Here is that list!
https://twitter.com/lologoblens/status/1346641650315980800 *

Also, until I was doing a She Ra rewatch for new year's I had totally forgotten that the vest Scorpia gets in the Crimson Waste has a ouroboros on it. So that was fun to see as I was working on this!

There's a playlist for this story cause that's a thing I do consistently now I guess. Anyway, it slaps and is 90% of what I've listened to ever since I burned myself out on listening to Aly and AJ's new album lolll....
https://open.spotify.com/playlist/22RKO35hbB5tpo4y?si=U004CJ_rmWbotMeQ

Come find me on tweeter @lologoblens and help me procrastinate on both my actual job and my hobbies.

Thanks for reading, until next time!

Goodnight Catra

Chapter Notes

> Symbols in this chapter are in a post linked in the endnotes if you want to follow along!

See the end of the chapter for more notes



Adora wanders into the lobby in a daze after Catra leaves. She should have stayed in the back;she realizes it as soon as she sees Bow and Glimmer's faces. Bow is plopped on the stool at the front desk with his eyes fixed on the door . Glimmer stands behind him, hand on her hips, eyebrow arched, and clearly waiting for Adora.

"What the fuck just happened? Did she chicken out?"

Adora swallows heavily and her voice still shakes like a leaf when she opens her mouth. "Uhnot exactly ."

Bow turns to her too, concern clear on his face. "You okay, buddy?"

"Uhh"…

Glimmer drops her hands and takes a step forward. "Adora...what happened back there? I've… *we've* never seen you like this after a session."

Bow nods his agreement and Adora deflates. "Bow?" He nods. "Can I steal your chair?"

"Oh my gosh!" He stands quickly and presents the seat to her with a flourish. She smiles gratefully and takes it. Her friends give her just

long enough to settle into her seat before, "So"…

"Right." She frowns, turning to look toward the front of the shop and out the windows to the sleepy street. She props an elbow on the desk and her chin in her hand. "Catra's mark."

"Did she not like the design or something? I'm confused." Glimmer says.

"I didn't *show her* the design." Adora corrects. A long silence meets her statement, but she can practically hear the silent communication surely going on behind her. "You know." She feels her friends still behind her and clears her throat. "You know how some people think markers don't even *have* a mate? We make so many soul connections, are destined to meet each… It's supposed to be enough."

"Adora," Glimmer starts, her voice the picture of reproachful concern, "you know that's just an old wives' tale. Did you… you have a mark, why wouldn't you have a mate?"

Adora blinks, fighting back tears. "Every soul has a mark, Glim. Not every mark has a match, some have multiple matches. You know it's not so cut and dried as two halves of a whole."

"Okay, yeah, but"…

Adora shakes her head. "I really only gave myself my mark as part of my training." She pulls her sock down to reveal her mark. The outline of a cityscape, trails of smog and a small cluster of stars rising above it, and a distinct outcrop all wrapping its way around her ankle. She studies it.

"It's beautiful." Bow comments softly over her shoulder. "Just like your soul, Adora."

She sniffs and a tear rolls down her nose falling onto her lip. "We just sat there."

"Huh?" Glimmer says.

"Catra and me." She turns to face them. "We just sat there."

"Like that's it? You didn't talk or do a pull or anything?" Her face scrunches, and she shares a look with Bow. "Could you not connect or something?"

She bites her lip and shakes her head. "I did." She whispers.

A looks of dawning understanding sets in on Bow's face. "Adora... do you... have feelings for Catra?" Another tear rolls, she nods. "Oh, oh Adora." Her wraps her in a hug and Glimmer looks on pityingly .

"So, that's why you couldn't?..."

"I-" Her voice cracks and she breaks off, burrowing into Bow's arms.

"Adora, you know , lots of people don't end up with their soulmate! Just because she has a different mark doesn't mean you can't shoot your shot."

Bow pulls back just enough to look her in the eye and nod. " *Totally*, she doesn't even seem that sold on the whole soulmate thing!"

Adora pulls away entirely and buries her face in her hands. "No, no you've got it wrong."

A beat passes and then, "Wrong how?"

Adora takes a deep breath and looks up at her two best friends in the world. "I just made a soul connection with her you guys, a-a one sided-I think I... think I *love her*. I barely *know* her, but I just made a soul connection with-with my *soul mate* and I love her and... and how do you *tell a person that* without sending them running for the hills?"

Their mouths drop and silence falls. Truly, at this point, there's not much left to say. Adora drops her head on the counter and settles in to wallow. She has a feeling she's gonna be there for a while.

Two days pass. Adora sees Catra without really seeing her, coming and going from work and her apartment across from the shop. She'd noticed her before they ever met. Catra is a striking woman after all. With her full mane of dark hair and her bright unmatched eyes. Yeah, Adora had definitely noticed her.

The first night they met for real Adora had ignored a distinct stirring in her gut. She mistook it for simple attraction. A soul marker by trade and she hadn't even realized…

Two days pass and Adora still has no idea what to do. She's distracted and knows that Glimmer and Bow can tell, but they give her space. And then Friday comes, and *space* becomes a distant memory. She finishes up with a client, a simple tattoo. After her session with Catra she'd postponed all soul mark appointments indefinitely. Her head was too out of the game to do her clients justice.

After going over after care and all that, Adora walks Huntara out. There, standing in her lobby, is Catra. And she has flowers, a massive bouquet of dark purple hydrangeas and soft peach roses. Huntara looks between Adora and the newcomer with a smirk and quietly sees herself out.

"Hey Adora."

"Catra." She blinks with her surprise, finally coming back to reality. "Hi. What um what are those?"

Catra smirks at her and Adora nearly faints, she was so not prepared for this. She'd assumed after refusing to mark her, Catra would avoid her like the plague. She certainly didn't expect her to just show up in the shop, and with *flowers* no less.

"Well, they're flowers, Adora."

Adora rolls her eyes, smiling at the sass despite her nerves. "Gee thanks. Why are you here with flowers?"

She holds them out. "A thank you."

Adora accepts them timidly. "Uh"…

"For the rock."

Adora laughs, a bit incredulous. "You're bringing me flowers for the rock I made you take? After." She trails off, regretting having started to begin with.

"Yep! So thanks."

Adora is so fucking lost. "Sure anytime, I guess?"

Catra laughs. "It's not a trick or anything. It's a nice rock, excellent paperweight."

A genuine laugh escapes. "Well, glad you got something out of the experience at least."

"Well worth it." She tells her in mock seriousness. At least, Adora thinks there's a jest in there somewhere. "Anyway, I should get. My shift starts pretty quick here." She jerks her thumb over her shoulder and Adora nods.

"Okay, well thanks. For the flowers."

With a smile and a nod, Catra is gone.

The next time Adora sees Catra, she's just arriving to the shop. Before she spots her, she sees Bow sitting at the desk with a shit eating grin on his face. On the desk in front of him is a vase filled with flowers. She doesnt recognize the sprays of yellow and white flowers nor the tall columns of rich blue, periwinkle and purple.

"Adora! Welcome to work. You got a special delivery"…

"Hey Adora." Then she spots her .

"Catra! Hi. You're here."

"Well spotted."

"Yeah why , um, are you here?" She looks between her and Bow . The latter just smirks and shrugs.

"I'm gonna go somewhere else." And with that her only hope for a buffer disappears. Adora turns and looks to Catra expectantly .

"Well I just wanted to follow up."

Adora walks closer. "Follow up."

Catra is leaning against the counter and shifts slightly. "Yeah, at our appointment I asked you if it was a not right then or a never"…

All the blood drains from her face, Adora can practically feel the loss of color. "Oh."

"So"…

"I'm sorry , Catra." She says dejectedly . "I- not right now ."

Far from deterred, Catra bounced on her heels. "Still doesn't sound like a never."

Adora laughs at her persistence and raises an eyebrow. "Not exactly ."

"I'll take it." She grins devilishly at her .

"And the flowers?"

Her grin turns even more deadly, Adora's heart may have stopped. "Maybe they'll inspire you."

"Inspire me?"

"Yep!"

"What are they?" She runs a finger over a spray of yellow flowers.

"Well, that's fennel."

"Fennel?" Adora laughs, raising an eyebrow. "Isn't that a food?"

Catra rolls her eyes good naturedly. "Stuff can be more than one thing at a time, Adora."

"I suppose that's true...and the other two?"

"Hmm, angelica, also sometimes called wild celery-"

"So, it's a salad?" Adora teases.

"You're an idiot, did anyone ever tell you that?"

"Hmm, once or twice."

"The tall ones are larkspur."

"That's not a vegetable." Adora points out, now on a roll.

"*Such* a dummy." Adora just laughs at the insult. "Enjoy your salad, I'm leaving."

Adora's still laughing to herself but stops Catra when she gets to the door. She sobers enough to say, "Hey Catra? I really am sorry. It's not it's something on my end getting in the way of my doing your mark."

Catra raises a skeptic eyebrow. "It's not me, it's you?"

A short laugh. "Yeah, something like that."

Catra waves a hand dismissively. "Don't sweat it, I can wait."

Adora watches her leave, cross the street and enter the florist shop across the way. Her heart aches.

"Adora?" She turns toward Bow's voice. "You know you have to tell her *something* right? Like take your time but you can't just avoid the issue indefinitely."

"Why *not*?" She whines, going so far as to stomp her foot.

He just snorts at her. "Adora."

"You know," She points a finger in his direction. "you and Glimmer had it so easy. You were already best friends! Of course I had to get the hot neighbor who flirts baselessly and has no idea what's coming."

"It's scary, Adora, no matter the circumstances. To offer someone your heart, unimpeded access to your soul. But, well, maybe it's not entirely baseless." His eyes drift toward the flowers on the counter.

Adora follows his gaze. They really are beautiful, like a firework show frozen in time. "What if...what if it's all too much? If *I'm* too much."

Bow chuckles. "Well, I can tell you firsthand that being loved by you *is* a lot. You never do anything halfway. Give her a little credit though, maybe *a lot* is just what Catra needs. She is your soul mate after all."

Adora turns to look back across the street. Catra is there, fussing with a display of fuchsia baskets. "She is," she smiles to herself, "isn't she?"

Adora actually recognizes all the flowers from Catra's next bouquet; Irises, peonies and sprays of baby's breath. It's beautiful, full and vibrant, and waiting on the doorsteps when she gets to the shop

Wednesday morning, two weeks to the day after their fateful appointment.

She picks it up and lets herself in. After setting it on the coffee table in the shop and flopping into a chair that nearly swallows her, she inspects it further. Amongst the blooms she finds a small note card. It's a small rectangle of gold cardstock. The message reads;' *Adora, Pardon my persistence. Just wanted to remind you I'm ready for that session whenever you are. No rush! Catra'*

She chuckles to herself and throws the card down onto the table. She sinks further into the chair with a groan, dragging her hands down her face. Bow is right, she can't just keep ignoring this. She's just so overwhelmed. Afraid too. What if Catra is disappointed? There is, of course, only one way to know. She stares at her flowers, her mood swaying rapidly between melancholy and enamored. Maybe tomorrow, she decides. *Maybe…*

The next time Catra appears, a few days after her absentee delivery, she doesn't come bearing flowers. Adora is in the shop late that night, all the lights off except the desk lamp to make it clear that the business is closed for the day. She's working on a tattoo design for a client. At least, she's supposed to be. At some point in the middle of thinking about Catra, she'd gotten sidetracked and started sketching their mark.

She knows it's not fair to never tell her. It's just so strange, Catra is a near stranger but Adora really, truly loves her. She knows her soul, and now she wants to know *everything* else. She'd just suck it up and ask her on a date but doing so feels like a lie of omission. She should know before anything happens, and Adora still has no idea how to tell her. And so, she remains stuck between a rock and a hard place, making a comfortable cave of her hiding place.

A knock at the door startles her from her musings. She looks up with a scowl, ready to wave off whoever is bothering her when they're

clearly *closed*. Instead, she finds Catra squinting through the door at her, and her scowl melts into a soft smile. Her soulmate perks up and offers a lazy wave once they've made eye contact.

She gets up and opens the door, ushering her in and locking the door again behind her. "You're here late." Catra comments.

"Oh, yeah, just trying to get a design worked out."

Catra turns to her and raises a brow, her expression reeks of teasing. "Wouldn't be a design for a soul mark, would it?"

Adora just smiles indulgently, making her way to the desk and quickly flipping over the sketch of their mark. "Hm, sorry, not tonight."

"Huh, well, can't blame a girl for trying."

"So, are you just here to give me a hard time or?"

"Oh!" She takes a Tupperware from under her arm and holds it out. Adora's brows furrow but she takes it. "I was baking and saw the light on. I just thought I... don't know, midnight snack I guess."

"You bake?" Adora asks, a teasing lilt sneaking into her voice.

Catra scoffs. "Not all that well, so don't get your hopes up or anything."

She opens the container and looks in. It's a small batch of scones and they smell divine. "What...?"

"Oh, uh they're scones, obviously. There's tarragon, oregano, and savory."

"I forget savory is a spice and not just a descriptor." Adora laughs, breaking a piece off one and stuffing it in her mouth. She groans without thought and her eyes fall closed. "Catra, these are *amazing*."

"Gross, dude. Swallow before you compliment me please." She's making a face, but her voice is amused so Adora doesn't take her too seriously. She does swallow though.

"My bad, but seriously, these are outstanding."

Catra just shrugs. "Can I see what you're working on?"

"Oh, I mean, if you want."

"I do." She smiles.

Adora nods and shuffles her papers around, putting the incriminating sketch on the bottom of a stack of papers. She grabs the design she was *actually* supposed to be working on and pulls it to the top. It's a little duck, she was going for regal looking, gliding through water. For the water she has a psychedelic rainbow design going. It's not quite there, but it's close.

"Adora, this is so cool."

The praise warms her from the inside out. "Thanks! I hope the client likes it at least."

"Well, they'd be a fool not to." She shuffles as if to get a better angle on the image. It brings her closer and their arms brush, Adora is barely able to suppress her shiver. "If you never get around to my mark maybe I'll have to come in for just a regular tattoo."

"I want to." Adora admits quietly, turning to look at Catra's profile.

Catra turns to face her too, she's a full head shorted but with her head tipped up like this their faces are *so close*. "Adora," she whispers, "what"…

"I don't know." Her voice stays soft, it feels as if volume would shatter something.

Apparently Catra thinks so too, because she also continues to whisper. "I don't understand what that means."

Adora's heart pounds, she can hear her blood rushing through her ears. She's at a total loss. Maybe it would be best to come clean now but the words escape her. "I'm sorry."

"You don't have to be." Her eyes drift down and Adora's follow suit. "Magic-all that woo stuff, I don't really get it, but I trust you."

Adora's not sure who moves but they drift ever so slightly closer. "I appreciate that."

Catra's eyes flick back up. "Adora, I"…

"You"…

"It's the craziest thing, I just feel like"…

She's so close, her exhales become Adora's inhale. "You feel like what?"

Her eyes fall again and then suddenly she clears her throat and steps back. Adora's heart sinks, but some part of her knows it's probably for the best. "Never mind, it's stupid." Her voice is back to a normal volume. Whatever there was to shatter has dissolved in their distance.

"I doubt it."

She shakes her head. "Don't worry about it. Um, I guess I should let you get to it."

"Oh, I'm probably done for the night." There's no way she'll be able to focus now. Her appointment isn't till late tomorrow afternoon anyhow.

"Gotcha, are you heading out then?"

"Yeah, I think so. Um, I can walk you home?"

Catra laughs lightly at that. "Adora, I live like, twelve steps away."

"Guess itll be a short walk then." She teases back.

"Whatever you say, Princess Charming."

Adora just laughs at the moniker and grabs her stack of papers and her keys. She follows Catra to the door and locks up behind them when they exit. They walk across the street and around the building with the coffee shop they both frequent. Evidently access to Catra's apartment is via a staircase in the back.

She doesnt say anything when Adora follows her up the stairs. After she unlocks the door she fiddles with her keys for a moment. "So, listen, maybe if you every wanted to grab coffee or something before work... Well, I know a good place." She winks and Adora almost falls down.

"Oh." Her voice is high and tight, very awkward. She clears her throat. "Yeah, that would be cool."

"Cool."

"Ill um, here, hang on a sec." Adora holds up a finger and digs around in the pockets of her pants until she comes up with a stubby little pencil. She puts her number on the corner of her sketch and tears it off. "Text me."

Catra smiles, the expression warm and genuine and so, so *soft*. "Ill do that. Goodnight Adora."

"Night Catra." With one last smile she disappears into her apartment, leaving Adora alone on the landing. She lingers for what is probably too long before skipping down the stairs.

She walks all the way home before remembering that she'd driven to work that day.

Chapter End Notes

Yes I *did* sneakily bump up the chapter count for this story and no, it probably *isnt* the last time. There we'll probably be five in the end. I don't make the rules. (Yes I do, I wrote the story. Don't @me. Or do, that's why I made a tweeter I guess?)
Speaking of;here's the list of symbols for this chapter https://twitter.com/lologoblens/status/1347260592769953

I was gonna post this yesterday but um...wow, that was a lot. If you live in the US and/or were plugging into the news I hope you had some time for some good self care!Pet your cat/pupper , drink some water, phone a friend, that sort of thing. Stay safe y'all!

As always, thanks for reading and I'll see ya nextime!

This Woo Woo Shit

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

✧♏✧

Catra disappears inside her apartment and collapses against the door. Adora lingers. She can practically feel her standing out there, it's the strangest thing. Once she's gone the racing of Catra's heart slowly settles. She's still a total disaster. What the fuck *was* that? Did she really almost kiss the woman she went to for her *soul mark*. That's it. would have been so stupid. At least she had managed to gather together *some* sense.

It's just this strange feeling that she can't shake. When she'd brought the first bouquet over, it was supposed to be a joke. They'd left things weird but they're essentially neighbors and Adora's chill, she just wanted to lighten things. At least that's what she told herself.

The second time, well, she'd be lying if she said she wasn't dying with curiosity about this whole mark business. She'd also be lying if she said she didn't just want to see Adora again. But maybe one little lie is okay, it's only to herself after all. Either way, a little flattery and inspiration never hurt anyone, right?

The third was intended more as an apology than anything. For being so pushy. The contrite feeling that had settled in her gut was her reason for delivering it when no one was around. Still, she couldn't resist the urge to press *a little*, if only passively.

Tonight well that was harder to come up with an excuse for. She's just been minding her own business, baking. Scorpia is visiting her moms, and unlikely to be home until tomorrow, so she had her music

going and was just puttering around. And then she'd looked out the kitchen window only to see Adora alone in a dark shop, working away. It was an impulse more than anything.

And now she has her number. Catra groans and peels herself off the door. *Of course* she'd find herself in this situation. She never even wanted a soul mark! So how the fuck has she gone and fallen for her fucking would be marker? Well, not fallen for, that would be nuts. She barely even knows Adora! Adora knows her though, right? She's made a fucking soul connection with her…

Mindlessly Cara goes through the motions of preparing for bed. Before she knows it she's lying in bed, wide awake. Her brain hurts. She just keeps replaying the moment in her head, back at the tattoo shop. The way she'd leaned in like a fool, how *close* Adora's face was, her lips…

She punches her pillow into submission and grumbles into it. She is *not* thinking about Adora fucking Greyskull one minute more.

Unfortunately, she has no say in the subject of her dreams.

Infuriatingly, Adora is the first thing Catra thinks about the next morning. It's not any singular thought, she's just on her mind. She covers her face with the blankets and pouts for a few minutes before launching herself out of bed.

The apartment is too quiet this morning. Catra wonders idly when the hell Scorpia is gonna get home. Who even likes their parents this much? She sees them like, all the time. Normally Catra loves having the place to herself but right now she could really use someone to vent to. She puts the kettle on and peers out the window. It's only nine so the only open business on the block is Sealineas. Watching folks coming and going from the café makes Catra remember the phone number laying on her bedside table.

She groans to herself and makes her stupid tea. And then she stands at the counter over the sink and looks out the window again. She notices Perfuma letting herself into Plumeria. She peeks at the clock; her shift doesn't start till noon but she *could* use some company. Surely Perfuma won't mind if she hangs out while she gets the shop ready for opening at ten. Especially if she brings a second cup of tea and some toast.

Her resolve settles and she gets herself ready enough to leave the apartment for a half hour. By half past she's tapping on the door and Perfuma is looking up from her sweeping to wave at her. She's let into the shop and Perfuma smiles at the mug Catra offers her.

"Lavender chamomile." She explains.

"Thank you, Catra. This is such a lovely surprise." Catra shrugs and circles behind the till to hop on the stool there. "Any reason you popped down?"

"Nah, just nothing better to do." Perfuma nods passively and resumes her sweep of the shop. Catra sips at her tea and watches her friend's progress. "So I heard you got your soul mark."

"I did!" Perfuma perks up and sets her broom aside to start fussing with the display at the counter. It puts her in a better position for chatting, which is nice. That's what Catra is here for after all.

"With Adora?"

"Yes! You've met her, right? She is such a darling. And so handsome!"

"Yeah yeah, she's cool, I guess. How uh, how did your session go? Like, how did that work?"

"Oh, it was very nice, Adora is so intentional about her practice. We chatted for a long time; did you know she's a sixth generation soul marker?"

Catra's eyebrows raise. "I didn't actually . She mentioned her sister but"…

"Oh, yes! Mara! I'm so excited to meet her after everything Adora told me."

"*Met* her?"

"Mhmm! They've posted about it a few times on the shop's social media. She's coming soon to do a guest spot at Greyskull Ink. Next week I think."

"Oh." Catra takes a large gulp of tea, unsure how to react to the information. "Chill."

Perfuma giggles. "Indeed. And you know , it appears good looks run in the family."

Catra snorts at her. "Fuma, you are just about the *thirstiest* bitch I have ever known." She just giggles at the accusation. "Your session was good then?"

"Fabulous. Are you thinking about getting your mark, Catra?"

She looks down into her teacup, swirling the dregs around the bottom. "I went in for a session."

She doesn't look up, but she can feel the careful way Perfuma looks at her when she doesn't elaborate. "You didn't go through with it?"

"She said she couldn't." Her voice is muted, but she knows Perfuma hears her. She looks up when no response comes and receives a gentle, perplexed look.

"She couldn't? What does that mean?"

Catra shrugs and rubs her upper arm gently. "I don't really understand it either. She said it was something on her end but that she wants to."

Perfuma hums and continues to give her that same contemplative look. "Well, I'm sure that happens sometimes. It must be such a sensitive business"…

Catra's shaking her head well before her friend trails off. "I asked."

"I'm sorry, Catra. You seem upset."

She shrugs. "More confused than upset honestly. And well there's something else." Perfuma waits, raising her eyebrows in a clear indication that Catra should continue. She mumbles out, "I asked her to get coffee and she gave me her number." and busies herself finishing off her tea.

"Oh! Are you interested in her?"

Her jaw flexes. "Isn't that weird?"

Fuma's head tips to the side. "Why would that be weird?"

"Just cause, well with my mark. Plus she's, y'know, seen my soul or whatever? It just feels weird."

"Hm, well yes, it makes sense that the imbalance of intimacy might feel strange. But Catra, deciding to get your soul mark isn't a contract. If you're interested in someone there's no reason you have to hold out for the possibility of a so called 'perfect match'. And Adora knows that better than anyone."

"I mean, yeah"…

"So, you *are* interested?" Catra's not so sure she likes the way Perfuma smirks at her.

"Fuck if I know. Maybe." Ready to move on she deflects, "What about you?"

She looks bewildered. "What *about* me?"

"You got your mark, are *you* holding out for a perfect match or whatever?"

"Oh." She giggles. "It's fun to dream about, you know? But no, I don't see any sense in closing myself off to possible connection for a big what if. More than anything I was just so curious to see what it might look like."

"That makes sense. Can I do you mind showing it off? I know it's really personal and all so-"

She waves her off and starts to pull down the sleeve of the lightweight cardigan she has thrown over her sundress. "Not at all! Honestly, it's pretty coo-"

She exposes her right bicep and Catra immediately starts howling. Perfuma turns red and looks beyond miffed-which like, fair. It takes a second for Catra to calm down enough to speak, waving her arms in front of her as if to clear the air without words. "Sorry! Sorry I just-" A few peals of laughter break free. Catra wipes tears from her eyes and Perfuma harrumphs.

"Just what exactly is so funny here?" She twists around to look at her own arm. "I think it's neat! It's an our-"

"I *know* what it is, Fuma." Catra sobers herself with a deep breath and raises an amused brow. "I saw Scorpia's when she got hers."

Perfuma stutters and stalls. "You -you can't possibly mean"…

Catra digs out her keys and holds them out. "She's out but she should be home within a half hour or so."

Perfuma reaches out halfway but hesitates before taking the keys. "The shop though we're open in ten minutes."

"*I'll* open the shop, dummy. Go get your girl."

She stares at the keys hanging in the air between them. "Well, she's not-"

"Please, you've seen what a dork she turns into whenever you're around. And *I've* seen the way you look at her-and her arms. She's gonna be thrilled. Go."

"I'll come back for the noon shift." She reaches her hand a little further forward.

Catra scoffs and shoves the keys into her hand. "Please, we both know I'll be fine here alone. Just open a window or something so my apartment doesn't smell like sex when I get home tonight."

She doesn't bother pretending to act scandalized. Just grins radiantly and nods. "I should bring flowers or something, right?"

"Hmm... Red tulips." Catra suggests.

"Brilliant!" She uses her arms to foist herself over the counter far enough to kiss Catra's cheek. She makes a show of acting disgusted and wiping it off. Still, when Perfuma starts bustling around getting her simple bouquet together, Catra watches her fondly. And then, in a whirlwind, she's gone.

Catra chuckles to herself and hops off the stool to finish getting the shop ready. Really all she has to do is pull the cash drawer from the safe and set out the displays. Still, she's got about five minutes left now, so she pulls on an apron and hustles to get it done. At ten exactly she's all set up, and just adjusting a bucket of yellow tulips out front.

"Hey stranger."

Catra yelps, nearly sending the bucket flying, and whips around. "Fuck, Adora, you scared the shit out of me."

“Grumpy today .”Catra would sure like to wipe that smug smirk of f her face. Or kiss it off. But that would be inappropriate. And weird. She settles for scowling back.

“Y eah, well, I started the day with herbal tea instead of coffee so.”

“Ah, undercaf feinated?”

“I wasnt supposed to start for a couple hours, thought Id have more time.”

“Is Perfuma alright?”Her face shifts from cocky to concerned in a second.

Catra raises an eyebrow. “W ell, I saw her soul mark”…

Adora looks elated. “Fucking finally!It’ s summer, how did it take them so long?”

A laugh. “Why didnt you just say something?”

“I’m a marker , not a matchmaker, Catra.”She just stares at her . “W e dont meddle like that. People have a lot of dif ferent motivations for getting a mark and it’s not my place to push an agenda. Besides, you know, there’s fate and all.”

“Blech, fate, spare me.”

Adora laughs, the sound full and homey and warm. Or maybe it’s just warm outside, it is summer after all. “Such a cynic.”

“I mean, yeah, but not entirely . I did just start work two hours early so those yahoos could get their shit together.”

“How noble.”Adora teases. “I suppose an act like that shouldnt go totally unrewarded. I was about to go to Sealineas, can I get you something?”

"You know, when I asked if you wanted to get coffee before work this really isn't what I had in mind."

"Well, since you didn't call I guess I'll have to improvise."

"Yeah, you heard the thing about two hours early, right?"

"Mhm." She bites her lips in a poor attempt to suppress her smile. "And you heard the part where I offered you caffeine, right?"

"You're insufferable."

"Why thank you, now, what do you want?"

"You know, you really don't have to."

"I want to, that's what makes it fun."

"Okay, well I can get you back…"

Adora rolls her eyes. "Catra, it's a coffee. It'll be like, five bucks max, don't sweat it."

"If you're sure I'd kill for a cappuccino right about now."

"Done! I'll be back in a minute." And without another word Adora skips off to Sealineas.

Catra watches her go for probably too long. The girl has a remarkably nice butt, so sue her. She shakes the thought off and scurries inside. There's not really much to do, it's a slow shift. She double checks they have no orders that need wrapping up and plops down on the stool when nothing turns up. She's just sitting there, drumming her fingers on the counter, when Adora returns.

"Hey Adora."

"Hey! A coffee for the lady." She presents the cup with a flourish and Catra realizes she should have given Adora her mug to save the

waste. Too late now, she takes a long pull and releases a satisfied sigh. "Hit the spot?"

Adora's watching her with an amused grin and Catra rolls her eyes, unable to fight the smile that rises along with it. "Yeah, thanks."

"Anytime." Adora leans against the counter, clearly settling in with no intent to leave now she's made her delivery. "So, what's the life in the day of a florist look like anyhow?"

"Very glamourous." Catra assures her with all the seriousness she can muster.

It earns her a snort. "Oh, I'd imagine."

"Honestly I'll probably just be babysitting today. We have a wedding next weekend though so that'll be a little more hectic."

"Aw, a wedding." Adora coos, no hint of irony in the comment.

"You would be a wedding person."

"I mean, I'm literally in the soulmate business. Plus, grand expressions of romantic love, dancing, pretty dresses; what's not to like?"

An image of Adora in a grand white dress flashes through Catra's mind and she gulps. Quickly closing the door on that vision, she asks, "Have you ever been to the wedding of a couple you've marked?"

Adora's expression goes dreamy. "A few, yeah. It's something else. I actually officiated for one. They were best friends and got their marks on the same day. I don't usually do more than one a day, but they insisted and I had this instinct..."

"Damn, that's wild."

She laughs. "No kidding. What about you? Weddings?"

"Like have I been to a wedding?" She makes a face at the question.

Another warm laugh. "No, like do you like them?"

"Ah." Another face. "In theory—yeah. Sure, I guess. Working here has kind of ruined weddings for me though. People get so worked up about the details and the production of it all. It's like, how often is it actually about the marriage, you know?"

"Hm, ever the skeptic."

"Please, you deal with a bride freaking out because the amaryllis are supposed to be white and you've given her *ivory* and tell me what you think then."

"Yikes."

"No shit."

"So—would you ever get married?"

Catra narrows her eyes at the question. It's very personal. Then again, she literally let the woman connect with her soul, so. "Depends I guess."

"On?"

"If I find someone? If they want to? I don't know, I'm really not that fussed. You waiting to be swept off your feet, Princess?"

Adora grins roguishly. "Who says I don't want to be the one doing the sweeping?"

Catra's gut flips. She forces a laugh. "Shut up."

"Hmm, don't think I will. I have a lot of very interesting things to say. I wouldn't want to deprive you."

"Sure ya do."

"Wow, okay, rude."

"I'm just agreeing with you, dude."

"No what it sounded like." Adora sasses.

"Don't you have like, a job? Or anywhere else to be besides standing here sassing me?"

"Mm, nope! I can go if you want me to though."

Catra's heart skips. "Do what you want. I could literally not care less."

"Can I read your palm?"

"*What?*"

Adora shrugs. "You said do what I want."

"And you want to read my palm?" Another little half shrug. "What, connecting to my soul wasn't enough for you?"

"You gonna let me do it, or just give me shit all day?"

"Whatever." Catra passes her right hand over the counter but Adora shakes her head.

"The left."

"Why?"

Adora gives her an exasperated look. "Are you always this difficult?"

"Pretty much, yeah."

She grins around her huff and explains, "I want your dominant hand."

Catra arches a brow. "How the fuck do you even know I'm left handed?"

"Uh, because I've seen you use a pen?"

"Whatever ."She swaps her hands around, ignoring the fluttering in her gut when Adora takes it in her hands.

"W ater hand."She mutters.

"Ex cuse me?"

"Y our hand shape. They correlate with an element;it means you're in tune with emotions and intuition."

Catra scoffs. "Okay , you're already bad at this. I don't have feelings."

"Please."She doesn't even look up from Catra' s hand. Instead, she starts tracing a single finger over the lines and ridges of Catra's hand.

Catra's lips fall open slightly watching her. Her gut flutters and, honestly, she's a little turned on by the soft caress of Adora's finger. It should so not be this easy to get her going. When the butterflies begin to boarder on unbearable, she clears her throat. "So?What' s the prognosis?"

Adora bites her lip and looks up through her lashes. "The truth?"

"Y eah huh."Catra garbles out, swooping her cof fee up with her right hand to take a drink.

"I can't read palms."

"*Hey!* "Catra yelps, pulling her hand back.

Adora is howling at her indignation and Catra huffs about it. "I'm sorry!I'm sorry , you're *face*. You were all like, Ack! *No!* Betrayal!-. oh I can't, it' s too good."

"Uh huh." Catra crosses her arms and watches Adora attempt to settle. "So, how many times are you gonna get me to do this woo woo shit without actually delivering?"

That does the trick. Catra feels kind of bad, she didn't mean to make it weird. She genuinely was just teasing. "Catra"…

"It's fine, Adora."

"It's not." She's pouting and Catra's as endeared as she is annoyed.

"Shut up, it's my mark and I said it's fine. I can always go somewhere else if I get suddenly desperate."

"No!" Both Catra and Adora's eyes go wide at the sharp exclamation.

"Uh"…

"Sorry, fuck, I'm so sorry. You um-of course you can do whatever you want. It's not-that's not my business." She's all sheepish now, picking up her own coffee cup and fiddling with the lid rather than taking a drink.

"Do you… Adora, are you still considering giving me my mark or? I just want to know. I'm not gonna go to anyone else, I honestly don't care enough to go further than ten yards from my house." With the mystery of Adora's hesitation she's not sure that's true anymore, that she doesn't care. She *does* want it to be Adora though. Just to find out what her deal is of course.

"I… yeah, it's not a no."

"Okay." She answers simply. Adora looks at her with something akin to awe. Time for a subject change. "Perfuma said your sister's visiting soon?"

"Mara? Yeah, she's getting her in a couple days actually. She'll be guest spotting at Greyskull next weekend."

"Chill, you guys get along then?"

Adora rolls her eyes fondly. "I mean, she's a pain in my ass but yeah. Do you have siblings?"

"Nope." She pauses to reconsider and adds, "I mean, there's Bonnie but she hardly counts."

"What?"

"Foster sister."

"Oh." Adora frowns. "I didn't realize…"

"How would you?" Catra asks rhetorically. "It's whatever. Bon and I just ended up in the same places off and on basically our whole lives. Our longest stint together was only like, nine months though. Still, we keep in touch."

"You moved around a lot then?"

"When I was older, yeah. I was in the same spot for like, eight years though."

"Can I ask what happened?"

"Nope. Sorry, Blondie. You're gonna need friendship clearance level sixty-nine to access my tragic back story."

Adora lets the joke lighten the air around them and laughs, giving Catra a goofy look. "Seriously?"

She shoots her a lascivious look and waggles her eyebrows. "It's a good level, worth the wait."

"Incorrigible." The bell tinkles behind Adora and they both look up. Some dude in a suit has let himself in and is looking at the ready made bouquets in the fridge up front. Catra sighs. "Guess I should let you get back to it then."

I guess.” Catra pouts, disproportionately disappointed at the idea of Adora taking off. “So when should I call you about making an appointment?”

“Appointment?”

“Hmm, you said it wasn't a no on that mark.” Catra reminds her slyly.

Adora lets out an exasperated laugh. “Catra! It's not a yes either, okay? I'll... let you know.”

“Whatever you say, Princess.”

Adora shakes her head and laughs again, waving on her way out the door. Catra watches the door swing shut behind her then polishes off her coffee before hopping to. Her mind flashes to the scrap of paper on her bedside table. Maybe she'll call Adora after all.

Chapter End Notes

Symbols for this chapter!
https://twitter.com/lologoblens/status/1347662652751843330

Did the chapter count just jump by two? Who did that? Next chapter was a late addition I'm excited for! It's not quite finished but nearly there!

Thanks for reading and to everyone leaving comments and kudos :))

A Very Good Feeling.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

✧ ♓ ✧

Perfuma lets herself into Catra and Scorpia's apartment. She's been here before, and obviously Catra gave her the key, but she still feels a bit like she's trespassing. She sets Catra's keys and her flowers on the table by the door and wanders in. Unsure what to do with herself, she roams the living room, peering at shelves and trying to guess what belongs to whom.

She's just toying with a little moose figurine when she hears the front door unlocking behind her. She turns in time to see Scorpia emerge from the hallway. Perfuma escapes her notice for a minute or two, she's fumbling a bit with a backpack, small suitcase, and her keys. It gives her a minute to observeher soulmate.

An internal sigh sounds at the thought. When Perfuma got her mark it truly had very little to do with the mate aspect. It is, of course, fun to think about. At the end of the day however, Perfuma has spent many years getting to know herself and building confidence in being that woman. Knowing this part of herself felt like a reward for all her hard work.

When Adora had opened her business across the street two years to the day after Plumeria's own doors opened it felt like a sign that Perfuma was walking down the right path. When she left her cooperate job three years ago it was a massive leap of faith, one that still terrifies her. The shop only started turning a profit in the last six months and getting there has been nothing short of exhausting. The

day she got her mark felt like finally making it to the other side, the grass greener than she ever could have imagined.

And then Catra told her that Scorpia shares her mark. Perfuma always found her so charming. Physically of course, Scorpia is just exactly her type; kind eyes, open face, and strong enough Perfuma can't help but wonder if the woman could bench press her. She's also so very genuine. The way she's able to soften even Catra, bristled and suspicious as she can be, makes Perfuma melt.

Perfuma *wants* to be nurtured and she has no doubt in her mind Scorpia Bream can provide just that.



"Oh! Perfuma!" Scorpia feels her cheeks warm at the sight of the woman standing in her living room. "Hi, how are you?"

Perfuma has a soft smile of her face and a twinkle of laughter in her eyes. Scorpia wants. Scorpia *wants*. She clears her throat and pushes the thought away. "Hello Scorpia."

"Hi." She rubs awkwardly at the back of her neck, unsure what to say. "Um, is Wildcat here or?..."

She shakes her head and bites her smiling lips for a moment before saying, "She's opening the shop today."

Scorpia's confused on two counts; one, she's fairly certain Catra wasn't supposed to work for another hour or so. In fact, she'd made a point to come home early enough to make them both lunch. And two, if Catra isn't here why is Perfuma? Catra must have let her in though, and she doesn't want to be nosy.

“Well...can I get you something to drink? You like herbal tea, right?”

She makes her way toward the kitchen, already prepared to get the kettle started. Perfuma giggles and stops her with her name, “Scorpia?” She turns, Perfuma has sat gingerly on the arm of the couch. “Don't you want to know why I'm here?”

Scorpia cringes slightly, maybe she was too obvious about her curiosity. “Oh! If you want to tell me. You're, of course, welcome any time. You don't have to explain to me.”

“I'd like to.” She inclines her head back to the couch behind her. “Sit with me?”

“Sure!” Perfuma stands but Scorpia hesitates, halfway to the kitchen. “I did...did you want that tea?”

“Maybe later.” She answers kindly.

Scorpia is generally very good at reading people, but she can't seem to interpret Perfuma's energy as they come together on the couch. She crosses one ankle over the other and Scorpia settles in next to her, picking up a pillow and hugging it in her lap. “So what's up?”

“I'd like to show you my soul mark.” Everything stops; time, Scorpia's breath, her capability to form complex thought.

Perfuma is Scorpia's dream girl. Sweet and soft, wit sharper than the edge of a sword. So sure, she'd stared longingly after dropping Catra off at work, wondering what it would be like to be the person lucky enough to have *Perfuma* as their soulmate. But that's all it was ever supposed to be, a fantasy.

Words are beyond her, so she just nods. Perfuma's smile practically glows, and she pulls down the sleeve of the pretty sage green cardigan she has on. And there, uncovered by the action is... “No way.”

There's an undecipherable look in Perfuma's eyes when the words fall from Scorpia's lips. "I think you're my soulmate, Scorpia Dream."

Her mouth opens and closes. Then opens. Then closes. Then opens. "I-I-I- are you sure?"

She giggles. "Well, I mean, I haven't seen your mark. Catra seemed to think ours would match though."

Wow, Scorpia just has the *best* best friend. "And that makes you?"

Perfuma reaches across the couch to take Scorpia's hands in her own and her eyes hold Scorpia's just as gently. "*Very* happy. How do you feel?"

And yes, those are tears. Perfuma's smile doesn't waver, she just waits patiently for a response. "I like I'm the *luckiest* woman in the *whole world*."

"Me too." The heat in Scorpia's cheeks is back. Perhaps it never even left. "Scorpia?"

"Yes?"

"Can I kiss you?"

"You wanna kiss me?"

She flutters her eyes with a fond air. "*Yes*, Scorpia. I've wanted to kiss you for a very long time."

"O-oh." Scorpia manages to stutter out.

Perfuma just giggles again, leaning in ever so slightly. "So...may I?"

"I'd really like that, Perfuma."

They lean together, eyes drifting closed, and Scorpia experiences the best kiss of her entire life. When they fall apart the air smells of

apple blossom and pine.

✧ ♓ ✧

Two hours after their first kiss, Perfuma lays in Scorpia's bed with her head on her chest. She's tracing her finger along, down between her breasts in no particular pattern, and listening to Scorpia hum some unrecognizable tune.

"Hmm, why didn't we do this sooner?" She asks, half rhetorical.

Perfuma feels as much as she hears the laughter rumbling in Scorpia's chest at the question. "Oh, because I'm *very* intimidated by you."

Perfuma can't contain a small giggle at that, propping herself up on an elbow so she can look down at her face. She tosses her long hair over one shoulder, shivering pleasantly at the slight tenderness in her scalp. "Not now though, right?"

"Psh, are you kidding? After *that*? Probably more."

Perfuma laughs and swats her shoulder, gentle and playful. "Stop."

Scorpia's answering expression is so soft and tender it's all she can do to not look away. Her soulmate looking so vulnerable makes *Perfuma* feel exposed. "You're an amazing woman, Perfuma."

Her heart melts like a candle at the end of its wick, going out in a puff of white smoke. "As are you, Scorpia." Her cheeks pinken and Perfuma lays her head back on her chest. She sighs in contentment, "*Soulmates*."

“Can you believe it?” Scorpia whispers, as if a spell has overtaken the room.

“That you were meant for me?” Perfuma can’t help but tease, reveling in the way she hears Scorpia’s heart stutter at the comment. “Yeah, I think I can make sense of that.”

They settle into a silence for a bit, Perfuma resuming her exploration of Scorpia’s chest with the tip of her finger. The sun steams through the window, casting shadows across the bed, and a bluebird sings from the tree outside. It’s a perfect moment. It feels like coming home.

“What do you think is happening with Catra’s mark?” She wonders aloud after taking ample time to enjoy the moment.

Scorpia sighs sadly. “I’m not sure. I don’t really know enough about the process to speculate as to what would keep a marker from marking.”

Perfuma hums in her agreement. “I just… have this feeling about them.”

“What kind of feeling?”

“A good feeling.” She answers, leaning up again to press a soft kiss to her lover’s lips. “A very good feeling indeed.”

Chapter End Notes

Symbols for this chapter!
https://twitter.com/lologoblens/status/1348006224860643329

Just a *breeeif* lil Scorpia/Perfuma interlude. I thought about titling this chapter Afternoon Delight which made me laugh but just felt a touch too on the nose, so.
Anyway, this might be the first time I've published POV besides Catradora? I think. I'm working on a fully Scorfuma story (By

which I mean regularly opening the WIP, writing two sentences and then getting stuck or distracted) so this was a nice lil practice round. Anyway, back to our regularly scheduled programing next chapter!

Thanks for reading!

Overthinking It

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes



“Adora!” Catra calls before she’s even made it across the street after she'd brought her coffee. And flirted. Just a little. She spins around and scoots back to Catra’s side of the street at her expectant look.

“What’s up?”

She pulls a sunny yellow tulip from behind her back. Adora takes it with a questioning look. “For the coffee.”

Adora can't help but laugh. “Thanks.”

“Alright, well I gotta hop back in. I don't think that sucker in there knows a dahlia from a dandelion.”

“Go, save him from himself.”

Catra laughs and Adora wants to live inside the sound. “See ya around, Adora.”

“See ya.” She waits until Catra is inside and she sees her greet the customer before turning to leave.

She walks into the shop, eyeing her new flower. She is so fucked. She looks up when a sharp wolf whistle greets her. Bow is sat on the stool, Glimmer at his shoulder, and they both have similar smug looks on their face. How either of them ever doubted their soulmate status is beyond her.

"Well, well, well, look who finally made it in." Glimmer taunts.

"Shut up! I don't have an appointment for another hour and a half."

"And yet we saw you arrive on the block nearly an *hour ago*. And come out of Sealineas with two coffee cups no less."

"Your point?"

"Adora." Glimmer's hand goes to her hip and Adora just knows she's not getting out of this conversation.

She still tries. "Oh, you know what? I think I left my phone in my car. I'm just gonna go real quick and-"

"You walked to work!"

"*What?*" She replies, dragging out the word as if to say, that's *crazy*.

"Your car was in the lot when we got here this morning. What happened anyway?"

Adora opens her mouth to respond, then closes it. She crosses the distance to the desk and hangs her bag on the hooks behind it. Her friends give her about two minutes of fussing before Bow prompts her again with, "Adora"…

"What?" She turns around to find two expectant faces.

"Why are you being weird? What happened last night?"

"Nothing!"

"Liar." Glimmer calls her out immediately.

"Fine." She pauses a beat then admits, "Catra came by." There's no response. Her friends are clearly waiting for more. "Whatever, we chatted, I walked her across the street, she suggested we get coffee before work sometime and I gave her my number. End of story."

"Uh, clearly *not* the end of the story. You were with her for like half an hour this morning! How did it go? What did you talk about?"

"How are you *feeling*?" Bow , ever the empath, interjects.

"Right, that too."

"It' s-I don't know we talked about stuff, whatever. Oh! She started work early-that's why I brought her coffee-because she saw Perfuma's mark!"

"Aw, I hope they get together!" Glimmer coos, allowing the distraction.

Bow nods along. "They are both such sweethearts."

"Totally!"

"I can't believe it took them, what? Like three weeks?" Glimmer laughs.

"That' s what I said!" Adora shakes her head and laughs. "Anyway , I need to do some final edits on this piece before my client comes. Glimmer, are you taking the back room in a little bit here?"

She raises her eyebrow but doesn't comment on the fact that Adora had stayed late last night to finish this piece. "Yeah, if that still works for you."

"Yeah, I think I'm just gonna use the meeting room to work. I'll use the front room for my session though."

"Sounds good." Adora starts to wander off but Glimmer stops her. "Hey , Adora?"

She spins on her heel, nervous as to what's coming. "Yes?"

"When does Mara get in? That' s this coming week, isn't it?"

"Oh!" She feels her shoulders slacken with relief. "Y eah, she'll be here day after tomorrow. She's only in the shop Thursday through Saturday though."

"Cool! W ell, you two should come over for dinner one night."

"Ooh!" Bow perks up. "Glimmy , will you make your buns?"

She lets out a tinkling laugh. "Sure, babe, I can do that."

"*Yes!*"..

Adora shakes her head fondly at their shenanigans and turns to go again. Glimmer stops her a second time. "Oh, and Adora?" She turns and sends her a bemused, questioning look. "Maybe you should talk to Mara about this Catra stuff. She'd know better than either of us, right?"

"Y eah." she sighs. "Y ou're probably right, Glimmer ."

Satisfied, her friend nods, signaling her release. Adora skulks off to her room, ready to lose herself in art for a bit.

Mara, like always, arrives in a whirlwind of chaotic energy. She texts Adora that she's parked out front, and she scurries downstairs to greet her. By the time she's made it to the porch, Mara has already piled more bags than any single person should need for a five day trip onto Adora's stoop. Immediately she pulls her into a tight hug.

"Heya K iddo!"

Adora laughs and shoves her off. "Shut up! Y ou're only a few years older than I am."

"Y ou're still the baby ." Mara sing songs back at her . "Now , be a good hostess and help me with these bags, will you?"

She crosses her arms. "You're insufferable, you know that?"

"Less talkie, more letting me inside. It's hot as tits out here."

"Yeah, yeah."Adora grumbles, irritated that she's right. She swoops up Mara's two lightest bags, which gets her a swift kick in the butt, and leads her up to the loft. "How was the drive?"

"Eh, fine. Long."

"Well, thanks for coming."

"Thanks for having me. I'm excited to see the shop."

Adora bounces on the balls of her feet as she unlocks her door and lets them in. "Mara, it's so beautiful! Glimmer did all the decorating so it's impractical as all hell, but so pretty."

Her sister raises an eyebrow, dropping her bags in a heap by the door. "Not your room, right?"

Adora scoffs. "As if."

Mara nods approvingly. "Alright, have you thought about dinner at all? I'm famished."

"I was just gonna throw together some pasta if that works?"

"Sounds great."Adora heads right to the kitchen, knowing if Mara's already asking about food, she's probably less than an hour away from hangry. Mara trails behind her and hops onto a stool at the island.

"So, how is Hope?"

Mara pauses her perusal of Adora's place to turn back with a smile. "Great! Same as ever, you know. Finally got her to agree to a vacation."

Adora snickers and turns away from the water she's set to boil. "She' s gonna leave work alone for more than a day?"

"She better ."Mara growls playfully . "I told her if she tries to bring her laptop, Ill throw a tantrum in the airport."

"Y ou would too."

"And she knows it."She smirks.

"Where are you going then?"

"Hm, my vote was Hawaii but Hope' s super hot on Italy right now. So, well see."

"I'm so excited for you, when are you going you think?"

"Late fall probably ."

"And who' s watching Darla?"Adora asks leadingly after their dog.

"Hmm I was thinking maybe-"

"I'm just gonna stop you right there and let you know if you say any name other than mine, Ill kick you right out. I don't give a shit if you're kidding or not."She points her spoon at Mara and her sister raises her arms defensively.

"W ow, being a business owner has made you *very* uptight."

"Hm, I prefer empowered."

"Psh, how about obnoxious?"Adora ignores the slight with a roll of her eyes. "The shop is good though?"Adora falters. "Uh oh"…

"What uh oh? No uh oh here!"She knows she has a tell, and that it' s impossible to miss. Still, no matter how hard she tries she can't keep her voice from raising several octaves too high every time she lies.

"Adora, please."

She deflates. "You want a drink?"

Mara narrows her eyes but answers, "Sure"…

Adora digs out a couple hard ciders from the fridge and pops them open before sliding Mara's over.

"So what's up, Squirt?"

Adora sighs and leans heavily against the counter. "Have you ever" She lays her arms on the island and starts picking at a hangnail on her thumb, dinner all but forgotten. "Have you ever not been able to make a mark?"

Mara's brow furrows. "What do you mean? Like have I ever had a hard time connecting with someone? You know that happens sometimes, right?"

Adora shakes her head. And focuses harder on the hangnail. It's starting to hurt. "No. Like after you've seen it."

"Can't say I have. Adora, what is this about?"

"There's this woman." Adora chances a glance at her sister, she looks concerned and it makes her stutter over her words. "Sh-she came in for her mark."

"Okay"…

"And it was" She groans. "Fuck, Mara, I've never connected with someone so easy. It took like, fifteen minutes tops."

"Wow, yeah, that's quick. Did you-I'm confused where the problem is."

Tears of frustration prick at the corners of Adora's eyes. She blinks hard to chase them away. "She-it's my mark."

She looks up and Mara's expression is frozen. After a moment it thaws just enough for her to ask. "Adora, you don't mean?..."

"My soulmate." She forces the whisper through her lips. Mara blinks. Then blinks again. And again. Finally, Adora whines, "Mar , shit, say *something*."

"I just-I'm not sure that's ever happened before, Dor ."

"*Eer?* " Adora's still whining and shakes her leg in a pouty dance. "*Come on!* There has to be some sort of precedent for this!"

Mara snorts at the move. "Sorry , Squirt, I don't think there is. At least, not that I've ever heard of. What are you gonna do?"

"I mean, I have to tell her , right?"

"You don't *have* to do anything, Adora."

"What? You think I shouldn't tell her?" Adora asks incredulously .

"I didn't say that. I just said you don't have to. C'mon, Dor , you know our marks don't decide our destiny ."

"Okay , well that's clearly not what I'm saying."

"Well then what are you saying, kid?"

Adora slumps forward and bangs her head on the counter. "*Ow!*" squeaks out at the move. Then she groans. "I'm in love with her ." She pauses and, deciding to just go all in, adds, "I'm pretty sure she asked me out."

There's a long silence and then suddenly Mara bursts out laughing. Adora stands back up to glare at her. She rubs at her forehead, she's pretty sure her confrontation with the kitchen counter is gonna leave a mark. Mara pays her no mind, actually bending over on her stool with the force of her laughter. Adora crosses her arms and taps her foot, waiting impatiently for the end.

"Alright, well, whenever you're done laughing at my misery ."

"Shit." Mara manages to huf f out, finally making an attempt to reign herself in. "Sorry , I just-only you, Adora Greyskull."

"Uh huh, are you gonna help me or what?"

"Adora, I think you might be overcomplicating this."

"What?" She yelps. " *How?"*

"Y ou have feelings for her, you just said she asked you out, she' s your *soulmate*, Adora, what more could you possibly need? The universe just served this girl to you on a silver platter and you're running scared."

"I am not *running scared*." Adora scof fs and crosses her arms.

Mara levels her with a look. "Good. Don't. Now , are you feeding me or not?"

And that, apparently, is all Mara Greyskull has to say on the matter.

✧♏✧

When Catra first moved in with Scorpia, it was out of necessity. She couldn't af ford to live alone on a florist's assistant's paycheck. Not anywhere worth living anyway. If forced she can admit living with Scorpia is actually really nice. She's good company, was always happy to feed Catra when she was at her most depressed after moving out on her own, and keeps her mess to her own bedroom.

Still, she never really *wanted* a roommate. Now, somehow, she seems to have two. At least that's what it feels like seeing as

Perfuma has spent nearly every night at their place since Catra sent her up to show Scorpia her mark. She's said it once and she'll say it again, Perfuma is lucky she's impossible to hate. Though Catra has to say she's surprised that holds true even when she's making moony bedroom eyes at her best friend over their dining table.

"Can you guys, like, get a fucking room please?"

Perfuma raises a cocky eyebrow at her but Scorpia blushes crimson. "Sorry Wildcat! We promised not to make you feel like the third wheel. I can start dinner if everyone is hungry?"

"That would be great, dear." Perfuma demurs, leaning over to kiss her cheek. Catra fakes a bit of retching but doesn't say anything because it's honestly pretty cute. Plus, Scorpia deserves to be doted on.

"What are you making?" She asks instead, once she's through with her bit.

"How do veggie burgers sound?"

"That works."

"Amazing." Perfuma smiles, grabbing her hand to give it a squeeze as she stands.

Catra looks away, her eyes straying out the window. It's honestly pretty homophobic that their window perfectly frames Honor of Greyskull. Like, can Catra not catch a break here? She's pretty sure she can even see Adora inside. Of course, all she sees is a flash of blonde hair before looking away, but still. It's her damn shop, odds are it's her.

Perfuma must follow her eyeline because she asks, "Did you ever hear anymore from Adora about your mark?"

Catra snaps her eyes over to bonus roommate. "No, and honestly I'm starting to feel bad for pushing it. She looks like she's gonna puke or something every time I bring it up."

Perfuma frowns. "I wonder what has her all in a tizzy."

Catra's gut churns and she crosses her arms, slumping down in her chair. "Yeah, you're telling me." She bites her lip and looks out the window again, pointedly looking at the old aspen tree outside the window.

"Catra?" Perfuma's voice pulls her focus back into the apartment. She looks at her expectantly. "I'm sure it's fine?"

She just scoffs at that. "If it was *fine,* I'd have a fucking soul mark by now."

"Wildcat." Catra doesn't turn to see the expression that accompanies Scorpia's reproachful tone.

"Whatever, it doesn't matter. It's not like I really wanted it that bad anyway. What do I care if Adora doesn't want to mark me?"

"Didn't she tell you that she *does* want to though?" Perfuma asks gently.

Catra raises her arms in exasperation and drops them on the dining table with a loud thud. "Don't you see how that makes it *worse*? What is so wrong with my soul that she wants to mark me and still can't?"

"Do you think perhaps you're letting your insecurity get the better of you here?"

"Whatever." Catra repeats. "Like I said, I don't even care. I'm not trying to work myself into a lather on principle."

"I dunno, Wildcat. Sounds like maybe you care a little bit."

Catra glowers at her. "Wow, okay Scorp. Just call me out why don't you? I *said* I'm *fine*."

"Perhaps you should just talk to her, tell her how you're feeling. Maybe she just doesn't realize how much you're challenged by all this."

Catra rolls her eyes at Perfuma's soft optimism and kicks her feet up on the free chair closest to her. "Yeah, I tried talking to her, Fuma. Every time my mark comes up, she looks like a kicked puppy. I'm not gonna kick the girl while she's down. I think I've pushed her more than enough."

"So," Scorpia begins. "No more flowers then?"

"Yeah, I think that horse is dead."

"Are you gonna ask her out though? You still like, *like* her, right?"

Catra snorts at the juvenile phrasing but answers nonetheless. "Maybe. I mean, yeah, she's cool so maybe I will. I think I'll wait for this whole mark business to blow over though."

Perfuma frowns, tenting her hands and resting her chin on top. "Well, whatever you think is best, Catra. I just hate to see you so troubled."

She scoffs and goes back to looking out the window. "I'm hardly *troubled*, it's just weird. I'll get over it. I shoulda just stuck to my first instinct on the whole matter."

Scorpia stands from where she's bent, sliding buns to toast in the oven. "What instinct was that?"

"I don't need a soul mark, and I never did." Her tone leaves no room for argument, and her friends know better than to push her. Still, she sees them share a look from the corner of her eye before a flash of blonde hair in the corner of the other pulls her attention once more.

Chapter End Notes

listen, it only got bumped up to seven chapter this time because I cannot count. I didn't *actually* add more between my last update and this one. I feel p confident 7 is gonna be the final count though!I actually have the ending outlined now and just have to go in and...y'know. Write it.

Anyway, symbols for this chapter are here; https://twitter.com/lologoblens/status/1348385488172773376 There are less and less each chapter going forward, just kinda worked out that way.

As always, thanks for reading and all the v sweet comments! Makes my day and helps break up the monotony of other stuff I have to do, like editing excel spreadsheets and zoom meetings which is totally what I'm gonna do now. And not work on that last chapter. ...Probably.
(If you see me on twitter...no you didn't.)

Peace Offering

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes



When Catra wanders into Adora's shop on Thursday evening there's a woman she's never seen before sitting at the counter. Her hair, eyes, and complexion are dark. She has Adora's nose, chin, and mischievous glint in her eye though, so she's pretty sure this woman is Mara. She feels suddenly nervous about her little peace offering.

Catra had sort of forgotten Adora's sister was coming this week. So, when she'd gone four days with seeing neither hide nor hair of Adora she'd been inexplicably on edge. She could have just texted, Adora's number is now both on her bedside table and on her phone, but this seemed more charming maybe? Now that Adora's older sister and mentor is smirking at her she's not so convinced.

"Hey, nice flower."

Catra looks down at the bowl under her left arm. "Thanks…"

"You have an appointment, or?"

She shakes her head. "Nuh uh."

Mara's smirk intensifies. "So, just here to hang out then?"

Catra can't help but roll her eyes at the teasing. Yeah, this is *definitely* Adora's sister. "Whatever, is Adora here?"

And now she just looks gleeful. "She just went to get coffee. She'll be back any second."

"Oh." Catra deflates. She hadn't really considered the possibility of Adora not being here. Seeing no appealing alternative, she walks forward and sets the bowl on the counter. "Uh, will you just tell her I came by? Or-I mean, that Catra came by."

"Oh no," Catra's taken aback by the firm denial until Mara says, "I think you should wait. She'll *definitely* want to see you."

Catra has literally no ideas on how to respond to that. She braces her arms on the counter and narrows her eyes at Mara. "Does being a little shit just run in the family?"

Mara's head tips back with the force of her laughter. Settling, she pushes her stool back so it balances on two legs. "So, you've heard of me."

"Oh yes, the notorious Mara. My boss is a big fan."

Her eyebrows fly in genuine surprise. "Oh yeah?"

Catra snorts. "Yeah, you meet Perfuma yet?"

"Not yet." Mara responds, a question in her eyes.

"She owns Plumeria." Catra explains, nodding her head back the way she came. "I'm sure she'll find an excuse to come by soon."

"Well," she says smugly. "always good to meet a fan."

"Stars alive." Catra mutters at the cocky smirk that stretches across her face. It's an echo of Adora's and therefore makes her heart flip. Mara just laughs.

Her cackling is cut off by the arrival of none other than her sister. "Oh *Adora*," Mara greets her in sing song. "Look who just so happened to swing by."

Catra turns in time to see Adora stop short in the doorway, a coffee cup held in each hand. "Catra."

She looksun..fairly good. Who even looks good in bro tanks? And the backwards ballcap? So stupid. It shouldn't look good, it' s not fair. Catra gulps. "Hey Adora."

That snaps her out of it, and she approaches the counter, handing one cup to Mara without looking at her. "Hey , what's up?"

"I-this is for you."

Adora looks at the bowl with a smile that's an interesting mix of cocky and shy. "A water lily?"

"Y eah."Catra clears her throat.

"Pretty ."

"Y eah."She says again.

"W ellth..ank you."

"Course."Catra is painfully aware of Adora' s sister watching them with avid interest. "Um, peace of fering."

"Peace?"Adora asks, bewildered. "I wasn't aware we were at war ."

That relieves Catra of some of the tension in her shoulders. "*War?* Way to be melodramatic about it, Adora."she teases.

Adora laughs. "Shut up. I don't understand the gesture is all I'm saying."

"I j..st-"She cuts of f, peeking at their audience from the corner of her eye.

Adora follows her eyeline and glares when she sees her sister leaning forward against the counter toward them. "Mara! Can you

like, I don't know, fuck off?"

Mara gives her a look. "You're really gonna have this conversation in the lobby?"

"*What* conversation?" Adora asks through gritted teeth.

Catra looks between them with curious eyes. This is so not what she expected to walk into. Mara's response is just as confusing as the rest of their conversation. "Aw, c'mon Dora. She brought you a *flower*. If not now, when?"

Adora looks up at the ceiling and seems to ask the heavens, "Why wasn't I an only child? *Why?*"

"Guess you were just too lucky." Mara teases.

"Uhh…what the fuck is going on?" Both sisters whip around to face Catra at the question. Mara looks viciously excited and Adora looks low key horrified.

"Ignore her, she lives to give me shit."

"Adora." Mara pulls her attention, expression and tone suddenly much more serious. "Seriously, come on."

If looks could kill…the sisters stare each other down until slowly Adora deflates. With a sigh she turns to Catra. "Are you busy?"

"Uh, I…mean I just closed the shop and Scorpia and Perfuma are in my house so, no."

Adora snorts at the comment and then sighs. "Wanna get your mark?"

Catra's jaw drops. She looks to Mara who looks extremely pleased with herself, then back to Adora who looks determined if not a little nauseated. "You're serious?" Adora nods. "I really wasn't trying to

pressure you. I-that was the kind of the whole point of." She tips her head toward the water lily floating in the bowl on the counter.

"Right." Adora nods and picks the bowl up. With her free hand she grabs Catra's hand. "Come with me. Mara, lock up if you leave?"

"Sure thing, Squirt."

"Squirt?" Catra questions with a smirk as Adora drags her back to the meeting room.

"Shut up." She answers without looking back. She pulls Catra through the door and closes it behind them. She sets her flower on the table between them and sits. When Catra continues to stand, just staring at her, she shakes her head in a sort of *what the fuck? Sit down.* gesture.

Slowly, Catra takes the seat opposite Adora. "So"…

"So." Adora heaves a sigh and the look on her faces echoes the one she wore when she told Catra she couldn't do *this*.

"What the fuck is happening?"

"I'm gonna give you your mark." She pauses. "If you still want it."

"Adora, I-"

She cuts her off with a shake of her head. "After you hear what I have to say, if you still want it *after*."

"Okay… you're making me nervous. Why are you being so weird?"

Adora pulls off her hat and runs a shaking hand through her hair before replacing it. "Sorry , sorry. I'm just trying to figure out the best way"…

"The best way to *what*?

Adora looks at her and slowly Catra sees resolve settle into her expression. She lifts her right foot to set it on the table. She's wearing black high top chucks and white tube socks. Slowly she rolls her sock down, hands shaking all the while. "So, your mark would look like this. Just um, on your left ankle."

She yanks the sock down to reveal what is unmistakably Adora's mark. It wraps all the way around her ankle, the outline of a cityscape. It's relatively detailed, trails of smog rise from some of the buildings and a constellation-cygnus Catra remembers-floats above. One of the buildings has a funny little outcrop. It's really fucking beautiful, and Catra can barely process it.

"Catra?" Adora ventures tentatively after what must be at least ten minutes.

"Adora?" Her voice is almost unrecognizable to her own ears.

"Do you can you like, say something?"

"No." she answers honestly .

"No?" Adora asks with a small, incredulous laugh. Catra shakes her head solemnly and Adora's expression sobers.

"Oh. Are you upset?" Catra shakes her head. "Disappointed?" She shakes her head again. "Okay . Okay so what?"..

"Fuck, Adora, will you just shut up and let me process for a second here?"

"Right! Yeah, sorry, of course, yeah um, totally."

"*Adora!* "

"Sorry!" She yelps bashfully .

With Adora finally quieted for the moment, Catra goes back to studying her mark. She keeps trying to form a thought, pin down a

feeling and she just can't. What she eventually comes up with is, "Were *you* disappointed?"

She looks up and Adora's face is the picture of horrified. "Catra, *what?* No! Of course not, why would you-"

"It's the first thing you asked me!" she defends. "And you didn't-or couldn't- I mean last time I..." She trails off, unsure where she's really trying to go.

"Okay, okay, yeah, that's fair. I swear I wasn't upset though, just… overwhelmed."

Catra laughs without mirth. "Yeah, I can relate to that." Adora laughs with her, a little more genuine but still awkward. "So, just to be clear, this means you're my"…

"Soulmate, yeah."

"Right." Catra looks at her-their mark again. "Can I be honest here?"

Adora looks incredibly nervous but invites, "Please, yes."

"I hate needles."

She laughs sharply. "Excuse me?"

Catra looks her in the eye, completely serious. "I don't really want you to mark me. I fucking hate needles. I just wanted to see it and well"…

"Now you have?"

"Uh huh." Adora blinks at her and then, seemingly out of nowhere, breaks down into helpless giggling. "*What?* Who gets stabbed repeatedly anyway? By *choice?* That's like that's literally masochism."

"Stop!" Adora manages to get out through her laughter. "Please, oh my-you have to...please stop!"

"*Adora!*" she whines. "Don't make fun of me!"

"I'm not!" Her denial would be more convincing if it wasn't forced out between peals of laughter. "I swear, I just-" She breaks down again and Catra crosses her arms, slumping back in her chair to wait out Adora's little fit. Finally, after several very *long* minutes, she settles. "Catra, you realize I'm literally a tattoo artist, right? Like, 'stabbing people repeatedly' is my job. And what were you gonna do if I said yes the first time?"

"I don't know! Grin and bear it I guess?"

Adora bites her lips, presumably to withhold more laughter. "That's stupid."

"Shut up! Rude, what kind of soulmate are you anyway?"

That seems to sober her a little more, but laughter still lingers in Adora's eyes. It looks nice there, they look brighter than before and immediately after her admission. "I'm sorry I didn't say sooner."

Catra shrugs. "Whatever, it's weird."

Adora nods. "Mara's pretty sure it's never happened before. A marker finding their own match like this I mean."

That gets Catra to sit up again. "Wait, you don't mean like… *never*?"

"Literally never. At least, that either of us know of."

"I guess you did say you weren't even sure you'd have a-are you *sure* you're not disappointed?"

"Catra!" She scolds.

"*What?* It's okay if you are."

"Well, I'm not." She says stubbornly, daring Catra with her eyes to challenge her again.

"So what now?"

"I mean, if you don't want your mark then that's really up to you."

"You don't care?"

"What we do now? No, I-"

"Not that, you don't care if I get my mark?"

She scrunches her face in confusion. "Why the hell would I care?"

"Well *I* don't know. I'm just asking."

"That's a stupid question is all I'm saying."

"Rude! You know, I never really counted on finding my soulmate. If I *had* imagined it though, I feel like I wouldn't have pictured getting insulted so many times."

Adora smirks and lifts an eyebrow smugly. "Aw, so what you're saying is I surpassed your wildest imaginings."

Catra laughs. "Sure, let's go with that." They settle into a short silence, just sort of staring at each other and settling into this truth. "Do you wanna like, get dinner or something? I know your sister is here…"

Adora smiles wide and waves her off. "Mara can fend for herself for a night. She's got other friends in town anyhow. Let's get food."

She stands and holds out her hand. Catra stares at it then looks down to her ankle again. She's left her sock rolled down, but it must have shifted up slightly when she stood because now only the tops of the buildings, the smog and the stars are visible. Catra trails her eyes up past her dorky cargo shorts, her outstretched hand, and all

the way up to her shy, tentative smile. Her eyes hold that same note of mischief they did the first time Catra met her.

Catra takes her hand and allows herself to be drug along.

Chapter End Notes

literally only one symbol in this chapter which is the water lily- for peace!

One more chapter (for sure this time) and it's the longest one yet!It's basically done so once I'm done fussing it'll be up and this would-be one shot will come to a close!

Thanks for reading :))

As Good a P ace as Any

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes



They end up at a bar and grill not too far from the shop. It's nice, not too swelteringly hot, and they're sat on the patio overlooking the lake a few yards off. It's a beautiful view but the entirety of Adora's focus in on the woman sat across the table from her.

Catra is so pretty. Like seriously , Adora has got to have the prettiest soulmate in the world. Her cute little freckles alone, *gah!* She's been studying the menu for a few minutes now and Adora just can't seem to stop marveling at her. It blows her mind just how cool Catra' s been about the whole 'you're my soulmate and I didn't say for the better part of two months' thing. Naturally there' s been a bit of a giggling awkwardness between them since they left Greyskull and made their way to the restaurant. Still-

"I can feel you watching me you know ."

Adora starts, registering the smirk that has slowly unfurled along Catra's lips. "Sorry ."She tells her bashfully .

Catra's eyes flick up, looking Adora up and down. "It' s fine, stare if you want. I know I'm hot."Adora fights the instinct to fan her own cheeks at the sheer confidence rolling off Catra in waves. "Might wanna look at your menu before the waitress comes back though."

"Right."Adora says, making no move to break her gaze or open her menu.

Her inaction earns her a roll of Catra's eyes. "You're an idiot."

She props her chin on her hand and smiles across the table. "Yeah, I know."

"*Your menu*, Adora. I'm hungry, I don't wanna have to ask for more time when she gets back here because you have no self-control."

Adora laughs and tears her eyes away with herculean effort. As she does so, she can't resists teasingly murmuring, "Your fault for being so cute."

"An idiot." Catra volleys back. "And I am not *cute*." Adora doesn't bother rebutting. She's pretty hungry too truth be told. Her focus pays off and she's able to choose something in time for the waitress' return. They place their order and the moment she walks away Adora is back to staring.

"So"…

Catra looks amused. "Yes?"

Adora props her chin up again and drums the fingers on her other hand on the table. "Soulmates."

Catra presses her lips together, pinching a laugh between them. "Mm hm?"

"Us."

"Adora?"

"Yes?"

"You going somewhere here or just rambling?"

The gentle ribbing makes her laugh. "I'm not sure. I feel like I should be. Guess I'm just curiouswhat you think?"

“About our being soulmates.”

“Oh Catra.”

“Shut up!” she laughs. “To answer your question, I don’t know, Adora. I mean, you know I’m into you.”

Adora can’t possibly let that pass without comment. “You’re into me?” she verifies with a waggle to her brows.

Catra is only so amused. Or at least, she makes a weak attempt to appear unamused. “I asked you on a date, Adora.”

“Yeah, but you never did call.”

“You were being all weird!”

“Hm, was I? I don’t recall”…

Catra snorts. “Shut up.”

“Anyway, you were saying. You know, about how you’re into me and all.”

“Starting to think I should take that back.”

“Ooh” Adora sucks her teeth and winces theatrically. “No take backs, sorry.”

“Adora.” She chides around a smile.

“What? I don’t make the rules.”

Catra crosses her arms and leans back in her chair, resting her right ankle on the opposite knee. “So, what do you think of all this? The whole-“ she uncrosses her arms to gesture vaguely at nothing. “soulmate thing.”

f-"Adora' s curious if her cheeks would feel as warm against her fingers as she thinks they would. She resists the urge to check. "Good."

"Good?" Catra checks, an even mix of humor and doubt in her voice.

"Y eah huh." She takes a gulp of her water .

"Adora, come on. That' s not a fully formed thought. Don't ask a question you're not willing to answer ."

She winces because like, that's such a *fair* rule. She blurts out her answer. "It' s really weird, okay?"

Catra looks taken aback. "Oh. W eird."

Adora scrambles to clarify, going so far as to lean slightly over the table. "Just-it' s a surprise first of all. Like, only so many people find their soulmates under normal circumstances and add to that the whole marker thing. . . I never really counted on finding you is all."

Catra softens and Adora follows suit. She hadn't registered the tightness in her chest until she felt it release. "Makes sense, I never did either." Adora shoots her a grateful smile, then hesitates. Catra doesn't miss it. "There' s something else."

It's not a question. "Maybe."

"Y ou gonna share with the class?"

"I don't want to freak you out."

Catra laughs a bit darkly and tips her head back and up to the sky. When she looks back, she levels Adora with a look. "Listen, I gave you a pass on keeping this whole not telling me we're soulmates for weeks thing, okay? Even though all you left me with was 'I can't' and 'It' s complicated.'"

"Catra." She holds up a hand to stay the interruption.

"I'm not down with this becoming like, a *thing* though. If we're gonna explore this, no cryptic shit. Lies of omission are still lies, Adora."
Adora purses her lips and twists them to the side, warring internally. "Adora?"

"Right, yeah, totally fair . Sorry, I'm just trying to figure out *how* exactly-"

"For shit's sake, Adora! Just say whatever it is you-"

"*I'm in love with you!*" She rushes out. Immediately , Catra's eyes go wide. "Look, look, okay , I know. I know! If a woman ever told me she loved me on a first date I would-shit, run for the hills? It's totally bonkers. But, well, extenuating circumstances?"

Catra clears her throat, looking no less caught off guard, and asks, "Extenuating circumstances?"

Adora scratches a phantom itch on the back of her neck. "I...made a soul connection with you, Catra. I know I...know we still don't know each other that well but I know you-your *soul*. And now I just want to know *everything else*. If that's okay."

Catra's smiling, a hint of mischief in her eyes. That's a good sign, right? "Of course, it's okay, dummy." Okay , yeah, definitely a good sign. But then...the smile falls. "You know...you know I can't say it back right now, right?"

Adora actually rolls her eyes at that. "And I'm the dummy?" Catra scoffs but visibly relaxes. "Of course I don't expect you to say it back right now. And I don't want to make you uncomfortable here. I'm not gonna be like, all up in your face and overly effusive or something. I *like* you, Catra-"

"You like me? How embarrassing for you."

Adora points an accusatory finger in her face. "Hey , don't start stealing my jokes there, babe." Catra raises her eyebrows at the

term of endearment but leaves it alone. "As I was saying, I like you, Catra."

"See and here I thought you loved me." She teases.

"You're insufferable, are you gonna let me finish my sentence or not?"

Catra fakes a pout. "You're no fun. Whatever, what were you saying?"

Adora huffs around a smile. "I wanna date you, and I want to see where this goes. But I dont want the whole soulmate thing to color this."

"Well, that's stupid."

"Wha-what?" That was so not the reaction she was expecting.

"Come on, Adora. What? Are we just gonna pretend like we dont know we're soulmates? Like you havent seen and apparently fallen in love with my *soul*?"

"That's not what I meant! I just dont want there to be pressure"…

She rolls her eyes. "Of course my soulmate would be an overthinker."

"Hey!"

She raises an eyebrow in challenge. "Am I wrong? Remind me again how long it took you to fess up about our mark."

Catra calling it *their* mark really distracts Adora from the rest of her point for a moment. "Okay, you may have a little, tiny bit of a point. You get what I mean though, dont you?"

She sighs and smiles kindly. "I get it." Any further response is cut off by the arrival of their food. They thank their server and settle in.

Adora digs right in but Catra hesitates, causing Adora to pause with her fry halfway to her mouth. "Adora?"

"Yeah?"

She doesn't speak at first, so long Adora decides to just go for it with her fry. She's washing it down with a drink of water when Catra finally speaks up. "Do you remember that night at the shop?"

She doesn't need to ask for clarification. "I remember…"

"I told you I have this feeling…"

"You never said what it was."

"It's still… a big feeling. I don't really know how to describe it."

"Intuition?"

She nods. "I think so." She reaches across the table to take one of Adora's hands. She squeezes once. "I don't think there's any ignoring the pressure. If I manage to fuck things up with my *soulmate* whose already in love with me…"

Adora frowns, this is exactly what she *didn't* want. "Who says you'd be the one to fuck it up?"

She shrugs and pulls her hand back. Adora regrets making the comment to instigate that. "That's really neither here nor there. All I'm saying is… well, it feels like I have something to lose here is all."

Adora melts entirely. "Yeah, yeah me too."

Catra sits up properly and picks up her fork. "Weirdest first date ever."

It makes her laugh and effectively breaks the tension of the moment. "Oh please, this isn't even in my top five."

Catra laughs. "Okay , well now Im gonna need a countdown."

Adora shakes her head, smiling fondly, and indulges her. And yeah, this date might not make it into Adora's top five weirdest dates, but it definitely makes it into the top five best. She has a nagging feeling that Catra's gonna take all five of those slots in no time.

In the end, it takes Catra two months to return Adora's sentiment. Adora herself doesnt say it often but she has no doubt that Catra *knows*. Mostly because she teases Adora about it often. Nothing hurtful, usually it's as a lighthearted reprimand when Adora gives her shit. ("Is this how you treat the woman you claim to love?")

By two months in they are well into U-Hauling. At least, that's what Adora considers it. Catra says hanging out a lot when they work three steps away from each other and she lives right upstairs isnt the same thing. Usually a smirk and a short, "Y es dear." is enough to make Catra roll her eyes and move onto a new topic.

Whatever you want to call it, theyre spending a lot of time together . Adora usually swings by the apartment before or after work, if she doesnt just wake up there-but that' s a fairly recent development.

The night before Catra says it, they lay with their legs tangled and heads together. Just minutes before, as Adora slowly returned to earth, Catra was sat cross legged at the end of the bed and had Adora's foot in her hand. She pressed lingering kisses reverently along their mark on her ankle. Adora watched for several minutes, mind and body nearly ready to shoot out into the ether once more, before she could resist the temptation to have Catra closer no longer.

"Hi." She whispers once Catra is settled.

"Hey hottie."

Adora scoffs. "Me hottie? Y ou-you're the," Catra makes her smug little face of amusement. "you're hot."

Catra laughs at her and pulls her somehow closer without breaking eye contact. "Dnt hurt yourself there, babe."

"Hm...okay ." Adora sighs contentedly and snuggles her head under Catra's chin. "Thank you. I love you."

The sudden stiffening of Catra's posture makes her heart seize. It' s a new reaction to I love you. Typically, she smiles fondly and tells Adora she's an idiot. Other times she pulls her in for a kiss and tells her, "Y ou're alright as far as soulmates go, you know that?" Her displays of affection are always coated in a layer of sarcasm and self-preservation but they're constant and Adora hears them loud and clear.

So, for her to not respond at all. . W ell, she does. Eventually. "Y ou dont have to thank me, dummy ."

Evidently, they're just going to ignore whatever happened. Adora tilts her head to kiss Catra's jaw . She teases, "But I appreciate it."

"Whatever . ust repay the favor sometime." She teases right back.

"Now?" Adora moves to pull away so she can look at Catra' s face, serious about her offer.

She's pulled right back in and Catra's voice is soft when she answers, "No, not now . ustst.ay . Please."

"I can do that." Adora whispers back, relaxing fully into Catra' s chest. Catra's hand in her hair pulls her toward drowsiness. Before she loses herself completely, she manages to ask, "Hey Cat?"

"Hmm?"

"Are youhappy?"

Catra sucks in a breath and holds her tightly. "So much it scares me."

Adora has to fight her fatigue by this point. "You don't have to all. I'll take care of you."

Catra presses a kiss to the top of Adora's head. "Promise?" She whispers.

"I promise."

The next morning Adora is making breakfast and chatting with Catra, Scorpia, and Perfuma who are sat around the table playing cards. Scorpia is telling them about her mother, Garnet, who met her soulmate the week prior. She and Scorpia's mom, Lynda, have been happily married for nearly forty years. She is also evidently the, self-proclaimed, World's Biggest Lesbian. So, she'd been tickled when the gentleman ringing up her groceries had pulled up his sleeve and revealed their shared mark.

As Scorpia tells it, they are already on their way to becoming great friends.

"I've been meaning to ask, Adora." Adora turns away from the stove to look at Scorpia inquiringly. "How does it all work anyhow?"

"Marks?" I thought-"

"Sorry, I meant like the connection. Is it like a feeling, or a vision thing?"

"Oh." Adora turns the burner down and crosses her arms, turning around and leaning back against the oven. "It's there's this feeling when it first happens. Like something just clicks. Typically, markers are able to keep their own walls up, we connect but the other participant doesn't totally connect back if that makes sense?"

"I think so." Scorpia says, turning to look at Perfuma who nods in agreement. Catra is staring at Adora so hard she avoids her eyes in order to stay focused.

"Right so, once you've connected, it's like... being immersed in their soul. Almost experiencing the world as if their soul was your own. It's really important to be grounded in yourself before engaging so you can hold both experiences simultaneously. And then the mark part is more like a vision. Or sometimes it's just a knowledge that settles in, like remembering something you've not seen yet."

"How was that different with Catra?" Perfuma asks. It's conversational and casual, and Catra whips around to give her a look Adora can't see. Adora clears her throat and turns back to the pan, feeling her face warm. "Sorry, was that too personal?"

"No, it-it's fine." She takes a deep breath and turns around again. Catra's eyes are on her once more, her expression pulling them into an inferno reserved just for them. "It was... totally different. There was the click and then... and then there was no hope of keeping my walls up. Our-our souls immediately intertwined and"...

"And?" Catra prompts, voice rough and eyes unblinking.

"And I fell so deeply in love with you, I knew there'd never be any looking back."

Silence follows the statement until Perfuma murmurs quietly to her partner. "Babe, remember I was gonna show you something? Downstairs." Vaguely from the corner of her eye, Adora sees Scorpia look between her and Catra before nodding vigorously. And then they're gone.

They're left alone and Catra's expression leaves Adora feeling vulnerable and exposed. Slowly she rises, walks over, turns off the oven, and sets her hands on Adora's waist. Her voice is thick when she speaks. "I don't think we ever talked about... how that went."

She hesitates before answering. "I didn't want it to be too much."

Catra pushes out a puff of breath that ruffles her bangs. "Give me a little credit, Adora."

"Okay ." she agrees readily .

Catra raises a skeptical brow but after a moment it sinks halfway, and she swallows thickly. "You said our souls intertwined." Adora nods. "And they are. Are they still?"

"I-"

"What did it feel like, for you?"

"I can't- it's different outside of just day today . But yeah, Cat, my soul is still wrapped up in yours."

"Adora"…

"Yeah?" The word comes out soft as a butterfly's wing.

"I *love* you. I love you but it doesn't feel… I love you with more than just my *heart*, Adora."

Adora sniffs and raises her hands to wipe the corners of her eyes where tears have gathered, blurring Catra's image. Then she reaches over and does the same for Catra. "I love you back."

At a loss for words, Catra pulls her in for a tight hug, pressing herself against her chest. Adora feels her heart beating, perfectly synced with her own in this perfect, perfect moment.

By the time Scorpia and Perfuma venture back, Adora and Catra have abandoned breakfast and retired back to the bedroom. Adora puts on music and lays Catra's head on her chest. Her lover sings along softly to Judy Garland's parts of Get Happy/Happy Days Are Here Again. Unable to resist her own elation, Adora joins in with Barbra midway through.

The song ends and Catra carries on with the next track. Their friends take over in the kitchen, soon filling the air with the scent of coffee. The sounds of their movement through the door make the apartment feel homey. Adora takes it in with the passive awe of a newborn, staring distantly at the jar of dark ambrosia and soft pink roses on Catra's bedside.

It's a perfect moment, one that will live viscerally in their memories for the rest of their joined lives.

It's two years before Catra gets over her fear of needles enough to decide she wants her mark after all. Adora double, triple, quadruple checks that she's certain and isn't just doing it because she thinks it'll make Adora happy (which is does). Catra finally just levels her with a look and with all the boredom she can muster says, "Don't be stupid, Dora."

Adora cries when she does it. Mara is in town and they have her on standby, just in case she gets *too* emotional. It's just a formality really, they both know it has to be Adora. The safety net her sister provides is nice but something in her soul knows it can't be anyone else.

After several hours she wipes ink and blood from Catra's ankle for the last time. Once her gloves are off, she scrubs the tears from her face. When she pulls her hands away, Catra is looking at her with an expression so tender her heart aches and she yearns for something she already *has*. It makes her tears start right back up again.

"Why are you crying, dummy?" Catra asks softly.

"I-" She sucks in a shaky breath. "I love you a lot, you know that?"

"Yeah, I know."

The nekxwords fall from her mouth without thought. "Catra? Do youwould you want to get married? T o me."

Catra rolls her eyes, presumably at the specification of to me'. She shrugs. "Whatever ."

Adora laughs and the sound is wet. "Whatever?"

She takes her hands and holds her eyes. "Adora, I love you."Adora pulls in a deep, wavering breath. "I'm committed to you. If you wanna have a party to celebrate that let's do it. Itll finally give me a chance to show off how good I look in a suit."Adora laughs and snuggles in close, burrowing her head into Catra's belly. From her new spot she can feel Catra's words rumble through her chest and it makes them feel more real somehow. Tangible. "I dont need it, Adora, but if you want it, Ill marry you in a heartbeat."

"Okay ."Adora answers softly .

Catra laughs. "Okay? Okay what?"

"Okayll.think about it."

"Sounds good."She leans back a bit, jostling Adora a bit and giving her room to poke her forehead. "Just dont go *over*thinking it."

"Psh, no promises."

"Y oure an idiot."

"Y our idiot."Catra gives her that look, the one where her mouth is smirking but her soft eyes blossom with honeysuckle and violets.

"Alright, *my* idiot. You gonna wrap this up so we can take Mara and Hope to dinner? Or were you just gonna sit here and make heart eyes at me all day?"

"I mean"…

She laughs and pushes Adora's head off her lap. "Dmmy , get me that wrap or Im walking out of here without it."

Adora narrows her eyes. "Y ou would never."

Saffron crocus sprouts between the blooms in Catra's eyes. "T ry me."

Adora huffs, thoroughly amused despite her best efforts, and pulls the wrap closer. Catra sets her left foot in her lap and Adora pauses. It's sosh.e' s having a moment.

When Catra told her she didnt want her mark, Adora had pretty much no feelings on the matter. Each time Catra brought it up over the last two years, sure Adora must have *some* opinion on the matter, she assured her honestly that she didnt care either way . Adora has seen this before, in a sense more intimate than most mates get to see their mark's match. She had no reason to care, and if Catra had never gotten her mark Adora could have died at complete peace with that.

All of this to say, Adora was in no way prepared for seeing her mark etched onto another's skin. Catra's skin.

"Adora?" Catra' s gentle voice pulls her gaze upward. "Y ou're crying again."

Adora touches her cheeks to verify that, yes, Catra is completely right. "Oh. I didnt even"…

Catra slides her foot off Adora's lap, hanging a leg on either side of Adora's. "Cmere." She makes grabby hands at her until Adora takes them into her own. Then she pulls her to standing, closer to eye level but now Adora rises above her by several inches. "Why didnt you tell me? What this was gonna mean to you."

Adora sets her forehead against Catra's, closing her eyes and shaking her head. "I guessI didnt realize. It' s your mark, Cat, I

wasn't lying when I said I didn't care."

"*Our* mark." She corrects.

Adora smiles and kisses Catra where their foreheads were touching before resuming her position. "Our mark." she confirms. "Still."

"I believe you. That you weren't lying. Will you… Tell me how you're feeling now."

"In love with you." Catra scoffs but doesn't move away. Wanting her closer, Adora drops her hands and wraps her arms around Catra's waist. Like a well-practiced waltz, Catra's arms rise to cross behind Adora's neck. "I mean it. I don't know how else to describe…"

Voice soft with intimacy she says, "I get it."

Adora's eyes flicker open to find Catra looking right back at her. "Really?"

She nods against Adora. "Me too."

Adora cries a bit more. "Yeah?"

"Yeah, you big sap. It's a big feeling."

"Like a grizzly bear."

Catra pulls away with a laugh. "Like a *what?*"

"Bears are big." Adora explains simply, like Catra might not know that already.

"Uh, polar bears are bigger."

"Is that true?" Adora asks, now fully on this tangent.

"Uh, duh babe. They're the biggest bear."

Adora puts a hand on her hip, not convinced Catra actually knows this trivia. "Oh yeah? What's the second biggest bear?"

"What am I, a fucking bear expert? I don't know what the *second biggest bear is*, Adora. I just know polar bears are biggest. Also, I apparently love you more."

"*What?*" Adora yelps. "No way!"

"Hey," She puts her hands up defensively. "I'm just saying, you love me a grizzly bear amount and I love you a polar bear amount. Polar bears are bigger, ergo"…

"Uh, no. I was working with incomplete information! If anything, all this proves is that you're smarter than I am, not that you *love me more*."

Catra smiles, clearly taking this as a victory. "Okay!"

Adora laughs in her face and drops back into her seat. "Don't act so pleased with yourself. Not like it was a secret."

"Let me have the win, Adora, or I'm going back to the great bear debate."

"Oh stars. Gimme that foot back."

"Yeah, yeah." Catra does as she's asked and watches Adora wrap the mark.

With that finally taken care of, they're ready to gather their things up to go. Mara and Hope are back at the loft and Bow and Glimmer have no more appointments for the day, so Adora gets the shop closed down and the alarm set. Once the door is locked, she makes to leave but is stopped by Catra taking her hand and holding firm. She looks back to her in question and Catra looks so completely vulnerable Adora's not entirely sure what to do with it.

kiss me?" Adora smiles wider and happily obliges. She pulls away once she's left Catra sufficiently breathless. With an uncharacteristically shy smile and her arms thrown around Adora's neck she says, "Hey . You're alright as far as soulmates go, you know that?"

Adora leans in close again, bracing one hand on the door frame and bringing the other up to cup Catra's cheek. She brushes her thumb against the soft skin beneath it, across her lips, and back. "Guess the universe just gets it right sometimes."

"Lucky us."

Adora laughs and pulls Catra in for a tight hug. With her face snuggled into Catra's neck she asks, "What do you think we ever did to get so lucky anyway?"

Catra hums thoughtfully, rocking Adora side to side. "I'm not sure, but I think you deserve the world, Adora."

"*You're* my world." She shoots back instinctively .

Catra groans but doesn't pull away or halt her slow swaying. "You're so fucking cheesy."

"I'm a *romantic*." she corrects.

And that is apparently enough because Catra finally releases her and shoves her off with a laugh. "I love you, dummy . Now let's go *eat*."

Hand in hand they make their way to the car. Unable to resist, Adora casually mentions, "So...you took the pain really well."

"Nope."

"What?" Adora laughs. "You-"

"You are *not* giving me any tattoos, Adora Greyskull. This was a one time deal."

"I never said-"

"You didn't have to, I know you."

"Okay , I'm just saying I know you like how they look, and I've *seen* you looking at stuff online"…

She stops by the trunk of the car and uses her hold on Adora's hand to position them facing each other. "Do you understand why I got my mark, Adora?"

"I mean, you just said you were ready"…

"I *got it* because I *love* that you and I have this weird, spiritual, woo woo connection."

"*Aww*, Cat"…

"Not finished. I love sharing this with you and every time I see your mark or kiss your ankle, I feel… Fuck, babe, I didn't know it was possible to feel so connected to another person without being totally codependent. I got our mark on my skin because I want to take that feeling *everywhere* I go.

"I love you; I love your art; you amaze me every day . But that? That hurt like a bitch, and no other tattoo is going to give me what this one has. I hope you enjoyed stabbing me repeatedly today , because this was your one and only chance to do so without having to face a jury after the fact."

Adora snorts at the final sentiment. "To be fair, this was a lot of blackwork. You could just get-" She cuts off at the fiery look in Catra's eye. "Not the point! You know I respect your decision, right? I don't mean to pressure you. I just thought since now you've actually *felt* it, maybe check in"…

"No, you're fine, Adora. You're an idiot, but you're fine."

Adora nods and a grin creeps back in. "That was pretty romantic you know, what you said to me just then."

Catra rolls her eyes. "Yes, well. I'm very in love with you so. Bound to happen now and again."

"Aww, you love me?"

"Shut up."

"Babe, that's like-"

"Shut *up*, or I'm not gonna say it anymore."

"You would never."

Catra's eye bloom anew, smirk firmly in place. "Nah, I love you too much."

Knowing better than to press her luck, Adora decides that is as good a place to leave it as any. She presses a quick peck to Catra's nose and circles around to the driver's seat. Catra's shortly behind her and soon they're off, driving off toward the sunset.

And that seems as good a place as any to leave it, don't you think?

Chapter End Notes

Hiiii!
I feel like ending a story on a question is a power move I never realized would be a power move? Idk, I feel powerful.
Symbols for this chapter:
https://twitter.com/lologoblens/status/1349770869875905

Final tally was at 60 for this story!(62 if you include the cancer and pieces symbols which I never noted. Oops🤦)
Also @aarkbeast1 on twitter made a beautiful art of Catra and Adora's mark. It looks way, way cooler than it did in my mind. (Since this story is rated teen and up;a note that their account is 18+in case you felt inspired to follow them. Which like, I do and would recommend-if you're over 18 obvi🤦).
Anyway, the link to that is here;
https://twitter.com/Qaarkbeast1/status/1340909559666625

Thanks to everyone reading and to everyone for being so posi about the ever changing chapter count! 😂 Not the first time and likely not the last so I appreciate knowing it's well received.
Until nextime!

End Notes

https://open.spotify.com/playlist/22RKO35hbB5tpo4y?si=U004CfrmWbotMeQ

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!